VISUAL HAMMER LAURA RIES

VISUAL HAMMER

Nail your brand into the mind
with the emotional power
of a visual hammer.

By LAURA RIES

OceanofPDF.com

Other books by Laura Ries

The 22 Immutable Laws of Branding
The 11 Immutable Laws of Internet Branding
The Fall of Advertising & the Rise of PR
The Origin of Brands
War in the Boardroom
(above books co-authored with Al Ries)

find them all at Ries.com

OceanofPDF.com

© 2012 by Laura Ries

All rights reserved.

Ries, Laura 1971-

Visual Hammer: Nail your brand into the mind with the emotional power of a visual hammer.

ISBN (Kindle): 978-0-9849370-0-4

Cover design by Matchstic

Author photos by Mary Jane Starke

Digital Editions (epub and mobi formats) produced by Booknook.biz

OceanofPDF.com

CONTENTS

Preface: By Al Ries

Chapter 1 – HAMMER: Its astonishing power.

Chapter 2 – NAIL: The ultimate objective.

Chapter 3 – SHAPE: Simple is best.

Chapter 4 – COLOR: Be the opposite.

Chapter 5 – PRODUCT: The ideal hammer.

Chapter 6 – PACKAGE: Make it different.

Chapter 7 – ACTION: More effective than stills.

Chapter 8 – FOUNDER: Natural-born hammers.

Chapter 9 – SYMBOL: Visualizing the invisible.

Chapter 10 – CELEBRITY: Pros & cons.

Chapter 11 – ANIMAL: Anthropopathy works.

Chapter 12 – HERITAGE: Putting the past to work.

Chapter 13 – YOUR HAMMER: How to find one.

Laura Ries: About the author

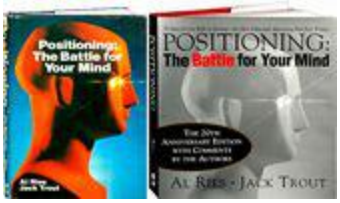
OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

PREFACE

BY AL RIES

Forty years ago, Advertising Age published a series of articles I wrote with Jack entitled “The Positioning Era Cometh.”



Nine years later, McGraw-Hill published our book “Positioning: The Battle for Your Mind.” In the years that followed, “positioning” became one of the most talked-about concepts in the marketing community. (In 2001, McGraw-Hill released a 20th anniversary edition of the book.)

To date, more than a million copies of the Positioning book have been sold, not including 400,000 copies in China alone.

Forty years is a long time for any idea to remain relevant, especially in the fast-changing world of marketing. By now, positioning is probably obsolete.

Or is it?

Many companies still write “positioning” statements for their brands. Many marketing programs call for establishing “positions” in consumers’ minds.

As recently as 2009, readers of Advertising Age selected “Positioning: The Battle for Your Mind” as the best book they’ve ever read on marketing. (That same year, the Harvard Business School Press published a book entitled “The 100 Best Business Books of All Time.” Positioning was one of them.)

Other authors are still writing books on the subject. In the last two years, “Positioning the Brand,” “Competitive Positioning,” and “Positioning for Professionals” were published.

Positioning seems to be still important in spite of the many revolutionary changes that have taken place in marketing in the last four decades. The Internet, social media, mobile marketing, the rise of PR. Then there’s Google, Facebook, Twitter, Groupon, LinkedIn and dozens of other digital ways to influence consumers.

As important and as revolutionary as these developments are, they are still tactics. And to be successful, a brand needs more than the latest tactic. A brand also needs a strategy and that’s why “positioning” continues to attract attention.

Yet the positioning concept has a weakness. Invariably, positioning strategy is expressed verbally. In executing a positioning strategy, for example, you look for a verbal hole in the mind and then you fill that hole with your brand name. Lexus, for example, filled a hole called “Japanese luxury vehicle.” Once the Lexus brand was securely positioned in the mind, it was almost invulnerable to competition.

In spite of the successes of “verbal” positioning strategies, it may come as a surprise to some readers that the best way into a human mind is not with words at all. It’s with visuals.

In 1973, for example, psychology professor Lionel Standing conducted a research study in which he asked subjects to look at 10,000 images over a five-day period.

Each image was presented for just five seconds each. When the subjects were showed pairs of images (one they had seen before and one they had not seen), they remembered 70 percent of the images they had seen before.

That statistic is phenomenal. Try presenting 10,000 advertising slogans for five seconds each and see how many of them a person will remember five days later.

In an over-communicated society, consumers will remember very few positioning slogans. No matter how cleverly constructed or how well your positioning concept tests in focus groups, if consumers can't remember your message, all is for naught.

What verbal messages stick in consumers' minds?

What's the glue that holds some concepts in a person's memory for years, even decades?

Emotion.

Think about your past. What events do you remember the most?

Those events that raised your pulse rate and your blood pressure. Those events that were emotional.

The day you got married. The day your daughter got married. The day you had your car accident. The day you got promoted. The day you bought your first house. These are all events you can "picture" in your mind.

Visuals have an emotional power that printed words or aural sounds do not. Observe people at a theater watching a movie. They'll laugh out loud, sometimes even cry.

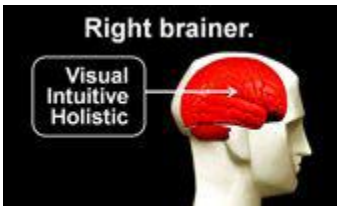
Now observe a person reading a novel, perhaps the same novel the motion picture was based on. Seldom will you see any outward signs of emotional involvement.

That's the difference between visuals on a screen and words in a book. One is emotional; the other is not.

Emotion is the glue that sticks a memory in the mind. But why are visuals emotional and words are not?

It’s because everybody’s brain is actually two brains. A left hemisphere and a right hemisphere.

Your left hemisphere processes information in series. It thinks in language. It works linearly and methodically.



Your right hemisphere processes information in parallel. It thinks in mental images. It “sees” the big picture.

In essence, every consumer has two brains. One verbal and one visual.

While the objective of a positioning program is to put a word or a verbal concept into consumers’ minds, the best way to do that is not with words at all. It’s with a visual that has emotional appeal.

But not just any visual. After all, advertising and other forms of communication are loaded with visual images.

What a brand needs is a visual that reinforces its verbal positioning concept.

The visual attracts the attention of the right side of the brain which sends a message to the left side of the brain to read or listen to the words associated with the visual.

The “position,” a verbal concept, is the nail. The tool that hammers the positioning nail into consumers’ minds is the Visual Hammer.

That’s Laura’s concept and I fully expect it to become as famous as Positioning ever was.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 1

HAMMER

ITS ASTONISHING POWER.

In the business world today, the printed word reigns supreme. Tweets, status updates, text messages, PowerPoint slides, emails, even old-fashioned letters.

Ideas, projects and marketing programs are all spelled out in a blizzard of words.

When it comes to executing a marketing program, no wonder business executives focus on the words alone.

Words are what they use the most and are most familiar with. Yet there is a lot of evidence that visuals play a far more important role in marketing than do words.

In 1982, Nancy Brinker started a foundation to fight breast cancer in memory of her sister, Susan G. Komen, who had died from the disease two years earlier.

Back then, Brinker says, her only assets were $200 in cash and a list of names of potential donors.

Since then, Susan G. Komen for the Cure has raised nearly $2.0 billion. Today it's the world's-largest non-profit source of money to combat breast cancer.

A recent Harris poll of non-profit charitable brands rated Komen for the Cure as the charity that consumers were "Most likely to donate to."

Ahead of such organizations as the American Cancer Society, St. Jude's Research Hospital, Goodwill Industries and the Salvation Army.

What accounts for the amazing success of a non-profit organization with the longest and strangest name in the field?

It’s the pink ribbon which has become a well-known symbol in the fight against breast cancer.

The American Cancer Society was founded in 1913, yet most people have no idea what visual symbol the society uses. That’s the real difference between designing a trademark and designing a visual hammer. Almost every brand has a trademark, but very few have visual hammers.

For his foundation to raise money for cancer research, Lance Armstrong did something similar to Susan G. Komen’s pink ribbon.

His yellow silicone-gel “Livestrong” bracelet was launched in May 2004 as a fund-raising device.

Sold for $1 each, more than 70-million Livestrong bracelets have been bought to date.

The bracelet is part of a “Wear yellow live strong” educational program. Yellow was chosen for its importance in professional cycling. It’s the color of the jersey worn by the leader of the Tour de France which Armstrong has won seven consecutive times.

Pink ribbons, yellow bracelets and other visual devices are transforming the non-profit world. But their successes are based on techniques borrowed from the business world.

In 2010, Coca-Cola spent $267 million in the U.S. advertising its Coca-Cola brand. What was Coke's slogan? Was it "Always" or "Enjoy?"

Or maybe it was "Coke is it?" Most people can't remember.

What do most people remember? What does 99 percent of the American public remember about Coca-Cola advertising?

Not the words.

Most people remember the "contour" bottle.

The Coca-Cola bottle is not just a bottle. It is a visual hammer that hammers in the idea that Coke is the original cola, the authentic cola, the real thing.

In a Coca-Cola commercial, the visual speaks louder than the words. That's the function of a visual hammer.

If you've noticed Coca-Cola advertising in the past few years, you've probably noticed a much greater use of its iconic Coke bottle. In print and television advertising, on the cans, on the packaging and on the billboards.

Even on letterheads and calling cards.

The company's visual hammer is one reason why Coca-Cola is the world's most-valuable brand, worth $70.5 billion, according to Interbrand, a global branding consultancy.

In today's global economy, a strong visual hammer is a particularly valuable asset. Coca-Cola is sold in 206 countries and 74 percent of the company's revenues come from outside the United States.

In many categories, global brands dominate local brands. In household and consumer products, global brands have 70 percent of the market in Brazil, 75 percent in China and 90 percent in Russia.

Unlike a verbal idea, a visual hammer can cross international borders with no translations necessary.

What is surprising about Coca-Cola's 6.5-oz. "contour" glass bottle is how few of them are actually bought.

No matter. The Coke contour bottle is a powerful visual hammer. A Coke can, on the other hand, is just another can of cola. That's why it was so brilliant to print the contour bottle on the can and even on plastic cups.

One place where the contour bottle is used quite extensively is in high-end restaurants, a fact that speaks to the visual impact the Coke bottle has with consumers.

While Coca-Cola has consistently used the same visual hammer, its verbal nails have been repeatedly changed. In the last 107 years, Coke has used 57 different advertising slogans. Most of these are totally forgettable like the 1941 slogan, "Coca-Cola is Coke!"

But four of these advertising slogans could have become long-lasting verbal nails for the brand if they had been used continuously.

"The real thing," in particular, is a strong verbal nail because it ties in well with the visual hammer.

The contour bottle symbolizes the authenticity of the brand and "the real thing" verbalizes that authenticity.

None of the other three slogans, as good as they are, strongly connect to the brand's visual hammer.

Today, “The real thing” lives on in newspapers, magazines, books and television shows in spite of the fact that Coca-Cola used the slogan only once, for just two years, more than 40 years ago.

That demonstrates the verbal potency of the idea. It also demonstrates the fact that verbal ideas can get stronger as the years roll by, a reason for keeping a slogan alive for decades.

Yet, why do most American companies do the opposite? It’s the unintended consequences of the annual slew of advertising “creativity” awards.

You can’t be a successful advertising agency today unless you can win your share of awards. And you can’t win an advertising award if you use last year’s ad slogan. It’s not “creative.” That is, it’s not new and different.

So ad agencies face a difficult choice. Win awards or perish. You can’t blame them for choosing the former.

Coca-Cola’s exceptionally-strong visual hammer puts its major competitor in a difficult position. What should Pepsi-Cola do?

The management at PepsiCo, like many other executives, seems to think that a visual hammer is nothing but a glorified name for a trademark. That’s why they tend to spend a lot of time and money perfecting their trademarks rather than searching for visual hammers.

Back in 2008, PepsiCo said it would invest more than $1.2 billion over the next three years revamping, according to chief executive Indra Nooyi, “every aspect of the brand proposition for our key brands. How they look, how they’re packaged, how they will be merchandised on the shelves and how they connect with consumers.”

As part of that revamping, Pepsi-Cola has a new trademark and a new advertising campaign which in 2010 the company spent $154 million promoting.

So today how many consumers know what Pepsi’s new slogan is?

Not very many.

Generally speaking, a trademark is not a visual hammer. If the "contour" bottle says "the original, the authentic cola," what does Pepsi's new "smiley-face" trademark say?

Pepsi's new "smiley-face" trademark says "Pepsi."

In essence, it's a rebus, a visual symbol that is a substitute for a brand name.

Almost all trademarks are rebuses. After years of constant use (and millions of advertising dollars), they are recognized as symbols that stand for brand names.

But they generally don't communicate much more than that.

And many brand trademarks don't even do that. Do you recognize these two? Reebok and Adidas.

Does your brand have a visual hammer? Or does it have a meaningless, rebus trademark? Or perhaps it has no visual at all.

Not all trademarks are meaningless. Nike has the Swoosh, a powerful visual hammer. What's the difference between the Adidas and Reebok logos and the Swoosh?

The Swoosh doesn't just say "Nike." The Swoosh says "leadership."

The trademark on Tiger's cap hammers Nike's leadership position into consumers' mind.

And it's not because the Swoosh is in any way special. Nike could have taken any simple and unique visual and over time its visual could have become a powerful hammer.

What gave Nike the ability to create a visual hammer out of a rather ordinary symbol? (A checkmark that has been streamlined.)

Because Nike was first in a new category.

Nike was the first serious athletic-shoe brand. And today, Nike dominates the category.

A visual hammer doesn't just repeat your brand name; it hammers a specific word into the mind.

For brands that can create and dominate a new category, that word is "leadership."

Like the Nike mark, simplicity is the key when creating a visual hammer. Too many trademark designers think they are designing a coat of arms for some mythical 15th century warrior rather than a symbol for a 21st century company.

Simplicity combined with uniqueness allows a visual hammer to be instantly recognizable at a distance.

The original Mercedes-Benz trademark had a lot of pomp but very little power.

Trademarks shouldn't be thought of as mere decorations. For market leaders, trademarks are potential visual hammers.

The new Mercedes trademark represents the ultimate in simplicity. Today, the Tri-Star symbol is one of the strongest visual hammers in the world.

As the original "prestige" automobile, the Tri-Star hammers "prestige" into the automobile buyer's mind.

Brands that create new categories have a singular opportunity to create a visual hammer that represents leadership and authenticity.

But not every brand gets it right. Take Red Bull, for example. The company created the energy-drink category which it dominates with annual worldwide sales of over $5.1 billion.

Despite its success, Red Bull doesn't own a visual hammer. It had the opportunity, but the visual it chose is much too complicated for a small energy-drink can.

"Two bulls and a sun" make a weak hammer. It doesn't measure up to the power of the Tri-Star, the Swoosh or the Coke bottle.

If the leader lacks a potent visual hammer, it gives the No. 2 brand a golden opportunity.

Monster entered the energy-drink market by positioning itself as the opposite of Red Bull.

Monster was launched with a 16-oz. can as compared with Red Bull's 8.3-oz. can. The large can and the Monster name link well in consumers' minds.

Monster also made a good visual choice. Claw marks in the shape of an "M" send a subtle message of "strength" and "danger" in a simple and effective way. As a result, you remember the Monster visual hammer.

Today, Monster is a strong No. 2 brand in the energy-drink market, in part because of its use of its visual hammer at concerts and sporting events.

In spite of these and many other examples, why are many marketing people working exclusively with words, when the real power is with the visual?

Well, words are also important.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 2

NAIL

THE ULTIMATE OBJECTIVE.

Since a visual has more emotional impact than a verbal, it’s logical to assume that the first decision a marketing person should make is what visual to use.

Not so.

That’s a paradox that is bound to confuse many marketing people.

While a visual hammer can be effective in building a brand, that’s not the objective of a marketing program.

The objective of a marketing program is to “own a word in the mind.”

BMW, for example, owns the word “driving,” an achievement that lifted the brand from nowhere into the world’s largest-selling luxury-car brand.

But what put the “driving” idea into the minds of consumers?

What’s was BMW’s visual hammer? It was a long-running, consistent series of television commercials showing happy owners driving their BMW vehicles over winding roads.

"The ultimate driving machine” was the nail. But it was the visual hammer was put that idea into the mind.

Without the hammer, in my opinion, the verbal idea would have been road kill. After all, “driving” has been a consistent theme of automobile advertising for many, many decades, including “We build excitement,” a long-running Pontiac campaign without a visual hammer.

But if the objective is to own a word, why fool around with a hammer? Why not just focus a brand’s entire efforts on a verbal approach?

Consider a nail and a hammer. If the objective is to nail two pieces of wood together, why fool around with a hammer? Why not just focus all of your efforts on putting the two pieces of wood together with a nail?

That's the problem of marketing. Your most important tool is a visual hammer which is redundant once you have nailed your idea into prospects' minds.

Well, not exactly. The three rules of advertising are (1) Repetition, (2) Repetition and (3) Repetition.

So you need to hammer away, not just for years, but for decades in not just your advertising but in everything you do from websites to business cards to annual reports.

"The ultimate driving machine" was launched in 1975. By 1993, BMW was the largest-selling European luxury vehicle in America. In the 18 years since, BMW has outsold the No.2 brand (Mercedes) 14 of those 18 years.

So what did BMW do recently? They switched the focus to "joy" and you can understand why.

Joy is a unique verbal concept that broadens the appeal of the BMW brand.

Which is true, of course, but how do you visualize it? Like many other high-level abstract words (happiness, enthusiasm, customer satisfaction, quality) joy cannot be visualized in any meaningful way.

Most marketing slogans are weak for exactly the same reason. They might express an important benefit of the brand, but unless they can be reinforced by a visual hammer, they are fundamentally useless.

What do consumers look for when they buy an automobile? Among other things, they look for: reliability, good gas mileage, good looks, nice interiors, drivability and the right size.

The first mistake an automobile manufacturer might make is to advertise all of these features. That's logical. That's what consumers want in a car.

Big mistake. When you advertise everything, your prospects remember nothing.

The second mistake is to pick the most important feature of your brand. But that only works if that feature can be turned into a visual hammer.

Take Volvo. Years ago, the company latched onto “safety” as its verbal nail, and then hammered the idea with dramatic television commercials featuring crash tests. Every year in the 23 years from 1970 to 1992 (except for the single year 1977), Volvo was the largest-selling European luxury-car brand in the American market.

In those 22 years, Volvo outsold BMW, Mercedes, Audi and Jaguar. Then in 1993, things started to fall apart.

In the last two decades, Volvo drove away from its safety focus. Gone were the crash tests. Even the slogan was weak: “Volvo. For life.”

In order to increase sales, Volvo tried to promote performance. They introduced Volvo sports cars, even Volvo convertibles.

As Volvo’s director of global advertising said: “Safety on its own is not enough.” That’s left-brain logical thinking.

Consumers don’t buy cars just because they’re safe. They look for a lot of other things when they look at vehicles on the showroom floor. But unless the brand gets into the consumer’s mind and unless the consumer gets into the dealer’s showroom, all that logical thinking is useless.

In marketing, everything else is secondary to the necessity of getting into consumers’ minds. And without a visual hammer, that job is

exceedingly difficult to do.

Volvo continues to drift downward. From a high of 113,267 vehicles in 1986, Volvo sold just 67,240 vehicles in 2011. That year, both BMW and Mercedes-Benz sold almost four times as many vehicles as Volvo. Even Audi sold almost two times as many vehicles as Volvo.

Volvo's biggest mistake was to abandon a successful visual hammer. When it did that, the brand suffered.

Over the long term, a consistent visual hammer is even more important than a consistent verbal nail, although it's better to have both.

Consider the Marlboro cowboy, perhaps an even more effective visual hammer than the Coke contour bottle. Introduced in 1953, the cowboy turned Marlboro into the world's best-selling cigarette. (The brand's share of the American market is 43 percent, more than the next 13 brands combined.)

Since its initial launch more than 58 years ago, Marlboro has never run an advertisement or an in-store promotion without using its cowboy imagery.

(Actually, since its "re-launch," as Marlboro was once a woman's cigarette, but that's another story.)

Nor has Marlboro ever used a woman in its "cowboy" advertising.

Many brands have tried to emulate the success of the Marlboro cowboy. Pick up a magazine, surf the Internet, turn on your television and you'll find hundreds of visuals that try to mimic the success of the cowboy.

Monkeys, donkeys, dogs, frogs, elephants, kids, babies, hot men, older men, hot older men, sexy women, older women, sexy older women, celebrities and many, many other visuals.

But most of the time these visuals never become hammers. Because art directors have selected visuals that are funny, serious, cute, sexy, or famous without first considering what the verbal ought to be.

You need two things to build a brand. A visual hammer and a verbal nail. And the nail comes first.

At the time of Marlboro's introduction, the vast majority of competitive brands were "unisex." Brands that made the classic mistake of appealing to everybody.

Marlboro was the first masculine cigarette. That's Marlboro's verbal nail. And what could be more masculine than a cowboy? (Not much, in my personal opinion as an avid spectator of professional bull-riding.)

Most brand visuals never become hammers. They might be funny but unless they are also functional they do little for the brand. A good example are the frogs from the famed 1995 Budweiser Super Bowl commercial, often listed as among one of the best commercials in history.

The commercial shows a swamp at nighttime with three frogs rhythmically croaking "Bud"… "Weis"… "Er."

Brilliant, right? Not in my opinion. Frogs croaking the name Budweiser? Where's the verbal nail?

Frogs, lizards, dogs, Budweiser has used them all and more. All the while, the brand has the ultimate visual hammer which it uses only occasionally.

That visual is the Clydesdale horses pulling an old-fashioned beer wagon. That visual hammers in the authenticity of the brand, the King of Beers.

That visual also says "old," which is a good thing in beverages. In technology, it's good to be new. In beverages, it's better to be old. Witness the success of brands like Dom Perignon founded in 1693.

Instead of sticking with the visual hammer it already owns as well as its companion verbal nail (King of Beers), Budweiser keeps searching for a new positioning idea.

A few years ago, Budweiser's "Wassup?" campaign won a lot of awards in part because it made for a great visual (two goofy guys talking on the telephone.)

But as a verbal idea it lacked motivation. What does "Wassup" have to do with drinking Budweiser beer?

The latest is "Here we go." Before that it was "Drinkability." Both of these verbal ideas are almost impossible to visualize.

Left-brain management tends to prefer verbal nails that encompass everything.

Like "Chevrolet runs deep."

Even if Chevrolet manages to put the "runs deep" idea into the mind, where's the motivation to buy a Chevrolet vehicle?

Then too, when your idea is a high-level abstraction or a concept that is broad and general, it's almost impossible to find a visual hammer that will drive the idea into prospects' minds.

Effective visual hammers need narrow nails like driving and safety. (Real hammers need narrow nails, too.)

How can anyone find a visual hammer that symbolizes democracy, loyalty, trust and other high-level abstractions?

Consumers tend to take verbal ideas literally. "Chevrolet runs deep" sounds like a slogan for a tractor brand.

Abstract ideas needs to be brought down to earth before they can be visualized.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 3

SHAPE

SIMPLE IS BEST.

Suppose you were put in charge of marketing an organization that called itself, “International Committee for Relief to the Wounded.”

What visual hammer would you use?

Forget the hammer. The verbal nail comes first. But none of the organization’s words (international, committee, relief and wounded) can be visualized in a unique way. Fortunately, five years after its founding, the organization changed its name to “International Committee for the Red Cross,” which is still its official designation today.

With 97 million volunteers, supporters and staff in 186 countries, the Red Cross is one of the world’s largest and most successful organizations.

(The American Red Cross is an independent organization that works closely with the International Committee for the Red Cross.)

When you are searching for a visual hammer, you start with the nail. But here’s the paradox.

Often you have to sacrifice some of its verbal meaning in order to develop a more effective hammer.

“Relief to the Wounded” is more specific and meaningful than “Red Cross.” No matter. “Relief and wounded” can’t be visualized while “Red Cross” can.

The ultimate objective of a marketing program is to hammer an idea into the mind. But sometimes it’s easier to hitchhike on an idea that’s already there.

The Red Cross has made the word and the color “red” synonymous with a non-profit charity organization. So U2 lead-singer Bono and Bobby Shriver (son of Sargent Shriver) created Product Red to raise money to eliminate AIDS in Africa. The Product Red brand is licensed to partner companies like Apple, Converse, Dell, Gap, Hallmark, Nike and Starbucks. Each partner company creates a product with the Product Red logo and a percentage of the company’s profits is given to the Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis and Malaria.

Product Red is the largest private-sector donor to the Global Fund and has generated over $150 million for AIDS programs in Africa.

It’s interesting to note that the Red Cross and Product Red are well known, but the Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis and Malaria is not.

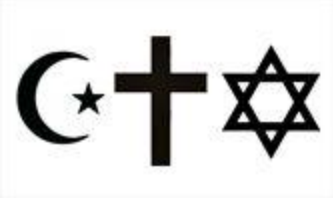
Where is the visual hammer for the Global Fund? It needs a name change to make one possible.

In other words, you sometimes need to sharpen your verbal nail before searching for a visual hammer.

As far as shapes are concerned, there are only a handful of unique shapes that most people can recognize.

Furthermore, most common shapes (the rectangle, the circle, the arrow, the triangle, the checkmark, the sun, the star, etc.) are used by so many brands that they have become virtually useless as visuals hammers.

Adding a unique color can help, but even then many color/shape combinations have been pre-empted. The Red Star by both Russia and China for example.



Simplicity should be your guiding principle when looking for a potential hammer. It's no coincidence that three of the world's major religions all use symbols that are extremely simple. The Star & Crescent, the Cross and the Star of David.

Many of the simpler shapes are already taken by existing brands. The "target," for example, is used effectively by both Target stores and by Tide detergent.

Tide's "target" hammer works exceptionally well because Tide was the first brand in a new category.

It also helps that the name "Tide" looks like it's stuck in the center of the target logotype. As far as the "target" of the Target stores is concerned, the utter simplicity of this design is what gives the Target trademark its power.

It may not be aesthetically pleasing, but in the retail category, the Target "target" is undoubtedly the most distinctive and most memorable trademark.

Compare Target's target with Walmart's new symbol, a six-petal design that resembles a sunburst or a flower.

Some reporters have speculated that the new symbol reflects former chief executive H. Lee Scott's goal of transforming Walmart into an environmentally-friendly company.

If so, the symbol does neither that job nor does it serve as the brand's visual hammer.

Too bad. Walmart is the larget retailer in the world, the dominant brand in the mass-merchandiser category. It should have been relatively easy for Walmart to develop a distinctive visual hammer.

The company's first try, a miniature star that also served a hypen in the Wal-Mart name, was banality at its best. The sunflower is a close second.

The trademark world is loaded with circles, squares, stars, arrows and other conventional shapes. Almost all of these shapes are useless in the process of creating a visual hammer. A better approach is to try to create a unique new shape.

One that has become well known around the world is the "peace" symbol, designed in 1958.

The peace symbol is unique, but it does share some similarities with Mercedes' Tri-Star trademark.

Recently, Under Armour created a unique symbol that has also become relatively well known.

Although simple, it's actually more complicated than it needs to be. At a distance, the mark looks like an "H" in spite of the fact that the designers obviously tried to create a symbolic "UA" for the Under Armour brand name.

In evaluating trademarks, one mistake marketing people often make is asking questions like: "How do we feel about the design? Is there anyway we can improve the way the design looks?"

A trademark is not a pair of jeans. What a trademark looks like is immaterial. The appropriate question to ask is: "What does the trademark

say?”

The object of a visual hammer is to hammer a word in the mind. In Under Armour’s case it is “leadership in moisture-wicking compression garments designed to be worn under sports uniforms.”

There’s no visual that can communicate an idea like that so it needs to be done symbolically. Luckily, the “UA” in the Under Armour trademark is not obvious to most consumers. If it were, the mark would lose some of its value as a “moisture-wicking” visual hammer.

Many companies use initials as a trademark. “HP” for Hewlett-Packard. “GE” for General Electric. “A” for Ally Bank. In effect, the initials are just shorthand symbols for the names themselves. They don’t necessarily hammer in any unique verbal idea.

An opportunity often overlooked is to verbalize your visual hammer. Coca-Cola’s “contour” bottle. Mercedes’ “Tri-Star” trademark. Nike’s “Swoosh.” Naming a hammer emphasizes its uniqueness.

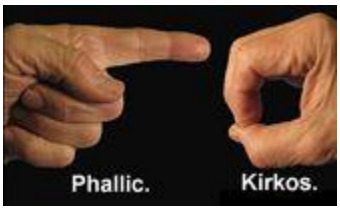
McDonald’s uses an initial “M” as a trademark. But by naming the symbol, “the Golden Arches,” the company moved beyond the rebus idea and turned the “M” into an effective visual hammer. The Golden Arches visualizes McDonald’s leadership in fast food.

Unlike what the art community might be telling you, visuals never work their way into human minds totally on their own. To be filed away in the mind, a visual needs to be verbalized.

Art critics, for example, will file this picture under “Cubism.” Then under “Picasso.” And if they are real experts under a subfile “Women of d’Avignon.” Artwork has no real meaning until it can be verbalized.

Watch art enthusiasts stroll through an art museum. If they don’t recognize a painting, they will quickly look to read the name of the artist who painted it.

A good visual hammer takes advantage of this phenomenon. To judge the effectiveness of a hammer, you constantly have to ask yourself, what is this potential hammer saying?



Because they create an emotional response, two of the strongest visual shapes are the phallic symbol, associated with the male sexual organ, and the kirkos symbol, associated with the female sexual organ. Visual hammers using either of these symbols can be particularly effective. Two examples: the contour bottle, a phallic symbol, and the Tri-Star, a kirkos symbol.

The weakest shape is the square, a deadly-dull visual. Why in the world would H&R Block, the leading income-tax service, use a green square as its trademark? Presumably, management thought, Well our name is Block and a block is a square. So we’ll use a square to remind people of our name and we’ll make it green to represent the color of money.

But that isn't the way consumers think. They don't see a "block." They see a dull, green, meaningless square.

Look at how many people use shapes in the vernacular. A "square" is somebody who is "not with it."

On the other hand, a "circle" is usually used in a positive way. As one of the social-media sites says: "Google+ lets users organize people into Circles of friends."

Neat, organized, buttoned-down people (typically left-brainers) often use squares or rectangles for symbols because they reflect their "don't-rock-the-boat" outlook on life.

But if you want to call attention to a symbol, you should avoid dullness at all costs.

Take The Gap, for example. The clothing chain's long-term logotype is a blue square with the letters "GAP" in white type. Not particularly eye-catching, so it was understandable why the chain wanted a new logotype.

But the revise was terrible. Instead of moving away from the dull blue square, the designer emphasized the square by using it assymetrically behind the letter "P."

What in the world was the redesign of The Gap logo trying to symbolize? Blue jeans for squares?

After unveiling its new assymetrical logo in October 2010, The Gap received a barrage of negative feedback from customers. The Internet was literally ablaze with the backlash. So the old logo was promptly brought back.

What should The Gap have done? Since consumers "verbalize the visual," one way to approach the problem is to "visualize the verbal."

What was The Gap's long-term slogan? "Fall into the Gap." Instead of a free-floating square, why doesn't The Gap try to visualize the "fall into" idea?

Perhaps by using a symbolic funnel or something similar that would hammer the "fall into" nail in the mind.

J.C.Penney is also following the footsteps of The Gap, moving from a square to a typographic logotype with a smaller decorative square.

I'm amazed that hordes of Penney customers didn't complain about the new logo. In additional to the dull square, why would the company split its name in half, so it reads: "JCP/enny?"

Furthermore, Kentucky Fried Chicken was often called "KFC," so that name change made some sense. But J.C.Penney was never called "JCP." So why use initials?

While the new J.C.Penney logotype is undeniably more attractive than the previous one, attractiveness is not the most important criteria in designing a logotype.

That's the problem with the Gatorade logotype. The designer made the orange lightning bolt so attractive that it doesn't look like a lightning bolt anymore.

It looks more like a knife than a lightning bolt. But it gets worse.

The name disappears on the new Gatorade logo to be replaced by the letter "G." That's a mistake.

Who calls Gatorade by its initial letter? "Give me a G" won't get you a Gatorade in any store I know.

Sometimes nicknames are used so often that manufactures are forced to include them on labels.

Coca-Cola, for example, was almost forced to use "Coke" on its beverage cans. But note: They didn't label the product "CC," because nobody called it CC.

How badly will the logo change hurt the Gatorade brand? In the short term, not at all. But in the long term, there are bound to be problems.

Marketing is essentially a long-term discipline. Marketing is more like a tree farm than a vegetable garden. In the long term, the Gatorade brand will suffer.

Consider the fact that worldwide 490,000 babies are born each day. That's almost half-a-million potential Gatorade consumers who will have to learn to associate the "G" with the Gatorade name.

Why doesn't the company make the learning process easier by keeping the Gatorade name on its logotype?

Furthermore, some 275,000 people die every day. Many of these are loyal Gatorade consumers who take their knowledge of what the "G" on the can means to the grave with them.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 4

COLOR

BE THE OPPOSITE.

Color can be an effective visual hammer, but the problem is, there are very few distinct colors in the spectrum. Five primary colors: blue, green, yellow, orange and red. And a handful of secondary colors.

If you happen to get in early, you can enhance the reputation of your brand by pre-empting a specific color. Tiffany, for example, has pre-empted the color blue.

Introduced in 1878, Tiffany “blue” has become a worldwide icon for the high-end jewelry store.

As a visual hammer, it communicates the elegance and authenticity of the Tiffany brand. The color is a private Pantone custom color and is even legally protected in the U.S. as a color trademark.

Tiffany stores have one thing in stock that you cannot buy. They will only give it to you. That is the blue box.

The rule of the establishment is ironclad, never to allow a box bearing the name of the firm to be taken out of the building except with an article which has been sold by them and for which they are responsible.

The Tiffany box is a very effective visual hammer. Put a blue box on a table and a white box from some other jewelry store next to it and watch the reaction of a typical woman. The blue box will generate an emotional reaction that the other box will not.

Kodak did the same with “yellow.” The yellow box communicates Kodak’s leadership in photographic film. A green box of Fujifilm just isn’t the same. Unless it’s a lot cheaper, or the store doesn’t have Kodak in stock, most consumers won’t buy “green” when they can get “yellow.”

But note: A hammer is useless without a nail. The yellow box hammers Kodak’s photographic-film leadership. But photographic film is practically dead today because photography has gone digital.

So Kodak made the classic error of trying to use its Kodak name and its yellow hammer on a line of digital products. The results have been dismal. In the decade of the 1990’s (from 1991 to 2000 when photographic film still reigned supreme), Kodak had sales of $125.2 billion and net profits after taxes of $6.9 billion, or a net profit margin of 4.5 percent.

In the following decade (from 2001 to 2010), Kodak had sales of $115.0 billion and lost $917 million. No wonder Kodak went bankrupt.

Compare Kodak with Shutterfly, a small company with a single focus (digital prints via the Internet) and a single color (orange.)

In the last ten years, Shutterfly had revenues of $1.3 billion and net profits of $56 million.

Kodak competes with Shutterfly using a website called Kodak Gallery. Another example of the folly of line extensions.

Why didn't Kodak give its digital-print website a different name? (In a big company, "loyalty" is the ultimate virtue. The principles of marketing are not something managers pay attention to when the principles conflict with their loyalties to their companies.)

What should Kodak have done? It should have launched a digital line with a different name.

Failing that, it would have been helpful to launch a Kodak digital line with a different color to differentiate its new digital products from its older photographic-film products. Much like Ralph Lauren did when it launched its highest-priced men's line as "Ralph Lauren Purple Label."

The Red Cross is one of the most famous charity organizations in the world. So back in 1929, a Baylor University executive developed a hospital plan which he called "Blue Cross." Ten years later, another organization was formed called "Blue Shield."

Blue Cross and Blue Shield developed separately, with Blue Cross plans providing coverage for hospital services, while Blue Shield covered physician services. The two organizations eventually merged.

Today, the merged Blue Cross Blue Shield Association is a federation of 39 separate health insurance organizations and companies in the United States.

Combined, they directly or indirectly provide health insurance to over 100 million Americans.

"Blue" is the color that strongly differentiates the brand. The confusion factor is the two names and the two symbols used together. Either one would have made a more-effective brand strategy and visual hammer.

(But in too many mergers, marketing effectiveness takes a backseat to corporate ego, trying to please both organizations.)

Sometimes you can take a simple product but paint it an unusual color and create a potent visual hammer.

In 1968, Mary Kay Ash purchased a Cadillac and had it painted pink to promote her line of cosmetics.

The car was such a good advertisement for the brand that the following year she decided to reward her top five producers with a pink Cadillac paid for by the company.

Today, Mary Kay Inc. has annual sales of some $2.5 billion. More than two-million independent consultants demonstrate Mary Kay products in the U.S. and some 35 other countries. Consultants vie for awards each year, ranging from jewelry to pink Cadillacs.

General Motors estimates that it has built 100,000 pink Cadillacs for Mary Kay to give to her top producers.

How do you tell one Caribbean island from another? They all have sand, sea, surf, palm trees and overpriced hotels. Bermuda found a way. Pink sand.

And Bermuda is not even in the Caribbean!

Is pink sand any better than tan or beige or white sand? No, but it’s different and that’s always the first thing to look for when you’re looking for a visual hammer.

Unfortunately, one thing Bermuda doesn’t do is to connect its unique pink-sand hammer to a memorable verbal nail. Instead it uses a cliché that could apply to almost any island or any brand. “Feel the love.”

In the world of professional golf, there are four major championships: (1) The U.S. Open, (2) The British Open, (3) The PGA Championship and (4) The Masters.

The first three are hosted by major golf organizations, but the Masters is hosted by a private club, the Augusta National Golf Club.

Guess which tournament draws the most attention? The Masters, of course.

One reason is the green jacket, the symbol of a Masters Champion. The tradition of the green jacket dates to 1937.

That year, members of the Augusta club wore green jackets during the golf tournament so fans in attendance could easily spot them if they needed to ask questions.

Visual symbols are not only memorable, but they tend to elevate the importance of the event or the person who wears the symbol.

When a leader of the Catholic Church is promoted to Cardinal, what picture is published around the world?

The new Cardinal in his red hat, of course.

(It is said that Cardinals of the Catholic Church wear red because it is a symbol that they are ready to shed their blood to defend their faith, a nice verbal nail.)

For years, the real-estate firm Century 21 insisted its agents wear gold jackets. You might be surprised at how many Century 21 agents object to wearing a “uniform.”

Yet the gold jacket was probably the best marketing idea the company has ever developed.

Century 21 sometimes uses the verbal nail, “The Gold Standard.” But the verbal nail might be stronger if Century 21 used it consistently and if

they had qualified it by saying, “The Gold Standard in Real Estate.”

And look at the success of Christian Louboutin, a French designer who regularly tops The Luxury Institute’s index of “most prestigious women’s shoes.”

In 1992, he applied red nail polish to the sole of a shoe because he felt the shoes lacked energy.

"This was such a success,” reported Mr. Louboutin, “that it became a permanent fixture.”

The red sole was the hammer, but what was the nail? It was the stiletto (heel heights of 120mm or more) which Louboutin helped bring back into fashion in the last two decades. To build a brand you need both: The red sole and the stiletto.

A color hammer is particularly effective in the retail field. It’s hard to miss a McDonald’s restaurant, even driving down the road at 50 miles an hour. Those golden arches are a visual magnet.

To capture the traveling motorist, Waffle House uses giant yellow letters to spell out its brand name. But many Waffle House units take the idea one step further. They use giant yellow awnings to reinforce the brand’s color identity.

What might the next step be? Paint the entire building yellow. This might be a good direction for almost any brand associated with a single color.

Red Roof Inn is a motel brand that uses its red roofs as both a color identifier and a visual hammer. What’s missing for both, of course, is a

verbal nail that would connect the red roof to some consumer benefit.

When it comes to color, many retailers miss the paint bucket. Retailers tend to design signage for attractiveness rather than for uniqueness.

Look at Exxon, one of the world's largest gas-station chains. Hertz is yellow, Tiffany is blue, Kodak is yellow, but what color is Exxon?

Exxon gas stations are not nearly as visible on roads and highways as single-color gasoline stations like "yellow" Shell locations. Or "green" BP stations. (Exxon is red and blue.)

The air-cargo carrier Federal Express got off the ground with a powerful verbal nail: "When it absolutely, positively, has to be there overnight." But what was the visual hammer?

The overnight letter, of course. When a Federal Express envelope arrived, the company wanted to make sure it received the maximum amount of attention from the recipient. So Federal Express picked two colors most likely to stand out in a dull office environment.

Purple and orange.

An excellent choice in the short term because the two colors were shocking, but not in the long term where a single color might have been better.

Then FedEx, the new name for the company, did what most companies do. After expanding into many other services, the company uses color to differentiate them.

Red for "express." Blue for "custom critical." Green for "ground." Etc.

Today, FedEx is a rainbow company, associated with no particular color. That's a typical pattern many other companies follow.

Its major competitor, United Parcel Service, took a different approach. Instead of using one of the popular colors you see everywhere, UPS selected "brown," one of the least popular colors.

(Most companies are focused on being "better" when the real opportunity lies in being "different," even in color.)

Today, brown is as strongly identified with UPS as blue is with Tiffany. So strong, in fact, the company runs ads with the headline, "What can Brown do for you?"

Brown is a strong visual hammer, but the current UPS nail is weak. "We love logistics."

(I love consulting. But "I love consulting" wouldn't make a good verbal nail for my marketing-strategy firm. It's much too generic.)

What would make a good verbal nail for a Brown hammer? Almost every good verbal nail is competitive in nature. It differentiates the brand from its major competitors. What differentiates UPS from FedEx? Not logistics, which both companies practice.

"Leadership" is what differentiates UPS from FedEx. UPS is the bigger, more profitable company.

“Brown delivers more packages to more places in more countries than any other carrier” might not be as lovable as “logistics,” but I think it would be more effective.

Everybody knows Starbucks is green, but what color is its competitor, Dunkin’ Donuts?

There are more than 6,700 Dunkin’ Donuts locations in America, almost all of them east of the Mississippi river. But most people don’t associate the brand with any particular color.

Dunkin’ Donuts signage is attractive but not nearly as memorable as the green mermaid at Starbucks and the yellow “M” at McDonald’s.

Ever wondered why beer bottles are usually “brown?” Actually, beer bottles were green in color until the 1930s when it was discovered that brown bottles filtered out the light that caused beer to go “skunky.”

(Sunlight breaks down acids in hops that react with sulfur to produce a chemical nearly identical to one that skunks spray. Gives new meaning to the toast “bottoms up.”)

In Europe after World War II, there was a shortage of brown glass, so many brewers of beer including Heineken exported their products in green bottles.

As the leading imported beer in America, Heineken became closely associated with the color “green.”

Trade papers called Heineken “The Green Standard.” Beer drinkers often asked for a “greenie.”

Today, the green bottle and the green label are a strong visual hammer for the Heineken brand.

But what is Heineken's verbal nail?

Over the years, Heineken has explored ideas like: "Seek the truth." And: "It's all true." And: "It's all about the beer." And: "Satisfy your thirst for the best." And the latest slogan: "Open your world." There's also the U.K. slogan: "Refreshes the parts other beers cannot reach."

These are all classic mistakes. A leader should emphasize its leadership.

At one point, Heineken had about 40 percent of the imported beer market, twice the share of Molson, the No.2 brand at the time, Then Corona from Mexico entered the market, with a powerful visual hammer, the lime on top of the bottle. By 1997, Heineken had fallen to second place.

At first, Heineken management disparaged the Corona brand, calling it "Mexican soda pop." Then they did something inexplicable.

They redesigned the Heineken label to enlarge what previously was a tiny red star. Then they built an ad campaign around the idea. "Stare at this for a long time and you'll see a red star." Naturally, the beer drinker was confused. "What? Is this supposed to be a Russian beer?" And Heineken fell further behind Corona.

You can change "words," but heaven help you if you try to change a "visual."

If you succeed in establishing a strong visual hammer (the cowboy, the duck, the lime, the straw-in-the-orange and dozens of others), you cannot

change your visual hammer without substantially damaging your brand.

So you're stuck with your current visual hammer. But what an effective device it can be for decades to come.

The surprising thing is how few companies picture their visual hammers on the products themselves. Why doesn't Corona use its lime on its label? And why doesn't Budweiser use the Clydesdales on its label?

Companies spend millions of dollars to put visual and verbal ideas into consumers' minds and then don't bother to put them on their product labels.

One of the remarkable success stories in the beer business is Coors Light, now with an 8.5-percent market share. (What green did for Heineken, "silver" is doing for Coors Light.)

The Silver Bullet has already passed Miller Lite, the first light-beer brand, which has fallen to 7.5 percent.

(Massive line extensions have greatly weakened the Miller brand. Starting with Miller High Life, the brand has been extended with Miller regular, Miller Clear, Miller Chill, Miller Genuine Draft, Miller Genuine Draft Light, Lite Ice, Miller Reserve, Miller Reserve Amber Ale, Lite Genuine Draft, Lite Ultra, Miller Genuine Draft 64 and others.)

Still, Coors Light is a long way from Bud Light which currently has a 19.1-percent market share.

But I predict the Coors Light brand will increase its lead over Miller Lite, thanks to its Silver Bullet hammer. And recently, Coors Light passed regular Budweiser to become the second-largest beer brand.

Budweiser, the King of Beers, struck back with a unique twist to reinforce its verbal nail.

The new Budweiser cans have a red pull tab with the “crown” symbol embedded in the tab. It’s a visual idea that is hard to miss.

On Budweiser bottles, the brewer has a new cap designed to keep oxygen out and flavor in.

Called “Flavor-lock crown,” the new cap uses a visual crown, but it’s not the same as the crown used on the red plastic pull tab.

That’s a mistake. Consistency in names, slogans and visual hammers is what builds brands. Not variety.

The same is true in colors. A single color is always superior to multiple colors. Compare Burger King with McDonald’s.

While McDonald’s seems to be everywhere, Burger King units are mostly out-of-sight.

What color are Burger King signs?

Most Burger King units have massive kids playgrounds. But that’s what McDonald’s is known for. So the logotype on the building is the only thing that differentiates a Burger King from a McDonald’s.

Two colors are difficult to remember, but three colors are impossible. The old Burger King logo at least looked like a hamburger. The new Burger King logo looks more like a piece of abstract art.

Sometimes the color a brand should use is obvious. Yet some companies even screw this up. Look at Virgin Blue, an Australian airline that actually painted its planes “red.”

How can it burn the name Virgin Blue in the mind with red planes? Red Bull made the same mistake. While Virgin Blue planes are red, Red Bull cans are primarily blue, except for Red Bull cola which is primarily red, the color of cola. (This is a line extension that won’t work.)

Quite often a brand starts off as a single color. Then management decides to line-extend the brand into a number of different categories.

So the problem arises, how does the brand differentiate itself between its various categories?

One of the most common ways is by using different colors. In the process, the brand’s original color is lost.

When it comes to color, retailers should not just try to associate a logotype with a single color. They should try to associate the entire store with a single color.

Years ago, Elizabeth Arden painted the front door of its New York City retail salon “red.”

The “red door” has become a trademark for the Elizabeth Arden brand, currently used on its 31 Red Door spas and also its line of Elizabeth Arden Red Door spa products.

FINANCIAL TIMES

Bush and Bernanke back fiscal stimulus

Bond insurers spark new fears over credit crisis

Almost every newspaper in the world is printed on grey newsprint, except for the Financial Times which is printed on salmon-colored stock. In an era where newspapers have been losing money, the Financial Times is solidly profitable and claims a readership of about 2.1 million.

It took a bit of courage to introduce a heartburn-relief pharmaceutical drug in a purple pill. At one point, Nexium, the purple pill, was the second-largest prescription drug in dollar sales in the U.S. market. AstraZenica, the maker of Nexium, even runs a website called (naturally) PurplePill.com.

Red is the color that demands the most attention. As in a stop sign. Something unusual is often called a “red flag” even though it has nothing to do with color or flags.

That’s why red is the most-used retail color. But that’s outside the stores.

Inside the stores, it’s a different matter. Retailers generally prefer laid-back colors like greens and blues to encourage consumers to focus on the products and not on the stores’ décor.

Enter Redbox, the big, garish, red-colored DVD-rental kiosks that are revolutionizing the video industry.

Inside a supermarket, they are hard to miss and their $1-a-night rental price is hard to resist.

While Blockbuster filed for bankruptcy in 2010, Redbox's owner, Coinstar, has been consistently profitable. Annual Redbox sales are approximately $1 billion.

Many old established brands use multiple colors. They were designed to look good, but not necessarily to stand out from the crowd. That puts them at a disadvantage in today's crowded marketplace.

What colors do MasterCard and Visa use? You probably don't remember.

Steven Streit had an idea to compete with the established credit-card companies. His idea was a prepaid debit card for people without a bank account or access to credit. What color should such a card use?

When you are first in a new category, forget artistic taste and expensive designers. The obvious color is green, the color of money. And what is the simplest symbol you can use?

A circle, obviously. So the name became Green Dot, the first prepaid debit card and a big success.

In four years of operations, sales have grown to $364 million annually with $42 million in net profits. Green Dot's recent market cap was a hefty $2.4 billion.

Look at the success of Green Mountain Coffee. Thanks to the increasing use of single-serve K-cups, the Green Mountain brand has grown rapidly. Sales in 2001 were $96.6 million. Ten years later, Green Mountain sales had jumped to $1.4 billion.

Sometimes you can also be successful by picking a color that is functionally less effective.

Look what an effective hammer the white earbuds have been for the Apple iPod. Personal products, especially clothing and products you wear with clothing like watches, are particularly good targets for visual hammers.

The iPod has 74 percent of the MP3-player market with nobody in second place unless you count SanDisk with its 7-percent share.

Electric wires traditionally have been black. Since wires are a necessary evil, the idea was to make them disappear. And nothing disappears better than black.

Apple did the opposite, always a good strategy for developing a visual hammer.

On the other hand, why call attention to the least important part of an MP3 player?

The white earbuds might be unimportant, but they let your friends and relatives know that you own an iPod, not some “imitation” brand.

The white earbuds, the contour bottle, the swoosh and many other visual hammers mine the same conceptual field. They visualize a brand’s authenticity.

It’s a shame that many leader brands ignore the easiest way to maintain their dominant market shares.

One leader brand that has done exceptionally well with a visual hammer is Campbell’s soup, the leading brand of canned soup ever since records have been kept.

Campbell’s red-and-white cans are an American icon, celebrated by Andy Warhol’s 1960 silk-screen prints. But as you can see, the pressure for change was apparently too much to resist. The red half is getting pushed off the can. How long will it take for Campbell to turn a red-and-white icon into just another can of soup?

At least Campbell has managed to resist what many companies have not. That is, using color to differentiate its varieties, rather than to differentiate its brand.

I wonder how many consultants have advised Campbell to put its pea soup into green-and-white cans, its chicken-noodle soup into yellow-and-white cans and its French onion soup into brown-and-white cans?

Any trip down a supermarket aisle will demonstrate that color is used primarily to help consumers pick the right flavor from a single product line.

A desirable goal, but secondary to the primary goal of identifying the brand in the first place.

And look at the effectiveness of Apple’s stark white trademark. Originally, Apple used a trademark in six colors. When you compare the two marks, you might think the old six-color mark is much more attractive and it is. But “identity” is more important than attractiveness.

Apple's "white" visual is unusually effective in identifying Apple products even at a distance. Apple also went the extra step in having the mark illuminated on its laptops. Also brilliant is the added touch of having a bite missing.

Compare BlackBerry with Apple. BlackBerry is a great name. It's unusual, it's alliterative and, in truth, BlackBerry is an even better name for a high-tech company than Apple.

One problem, however. But how do you visualize a "blackberry?"

BlackBerry's attempt to use blackberry seeds as an identifying device for its brand is pretty lame. The odd shapes don't look like much of anything.

Applebee's Neighborhood Grill & Bar is the largest casual-dining chain in America with 1,862 units and 2010 sales of $4.3 billion.

The Applebee's name was apparently created by combining a number of different words in order to find a euphonious pair. In the alphabet, "a" is first and "b" is second so Applebee's sounds like a natural combination whereas Beeapple's sounds weird.

In addition, Applebee's wisely uses a red apple as a visual symbol for the brand. But why use a symbol that visualizes only half of the chain's brand name?

Applebee's could have used two symbols, a bee and an apple. That sounds logical, but visually it's wrong. One symbol is memorable; two symbols are confusing. .

Another fruit brand name is “Pinkberry,” a rapidly growing chain of upscale frozen desserts. Currently there are some 135 units selling tart desserts to a groupie-like following who often call the product “Crackberry.”

Blueberries are blue, blackberries are black, but pinkberries are green?

That’s not a good idea because it can easily cause mental confusion. The entire logo should have been pink.

One of Pinkberry competitors, Red Mango, a frozen yogurt and smoothie brand, was actually first in the market, but has grown at a slower pace with only some 100 units to date.

But Red Mango’s signage uses a fluorescent-red circle which is not only visually distinctive, but also reinforces the brand name.

Using a color as part of your brand name is often a good idea, especially in a category that lacks “color” names. But keep in mind that consumers take brand names quite literally. Your “color” brand needs a visual hammer that uses the same color as your brand name.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 5

PRODUCT

THE IDEAL HAMMER.

If you can design your product so that it incorporates a visual hammer, you can have a huge advantage in the marketplace.

Being first, of course, is particularly helpful. When you are first, a distinctive design is living proof of your leadership in the category.

No brand has exploited this advantage as well as the Swiss watch, Rolex.

Its unique watchband is a status symbol as well as a visual hammer that positions the brand in consumers' minds as the leader in luxury watches.

As is true with many brands, Rolex was not the first luxury watch brand in the market. But it was the first luxury watch brand in the mind.

The arrival of a new category is usually marked by an avalanche of new brands.

There have been hundreds of brands of personal computers, for example. And thousands of brands of energy drinks.

Take the latest high-technology product, the tablet computer. In January of 2011, more than 80 such devices were announced at the Consumer Electronics Show.

With so many brands in every category, it's highly unlikely that the leading brand will be the "best" product.

A good product perhaps, but not necessarily better than many other brands in the same category.

"Life is unfair," said John F. Kennedy. That's true, in marketing as well as in politics.

In spite of much evidence to the contrary, many marketing people assume the leading brand is the better product. Not true.

In the consumer field, for example, Consumer Reports, one of the few independent organizations that exhaustively tests products, often finds that secondary brands are clearly superior to market leaders.

In its coffee tests, McDonald's surprisingly beat Starbucks on taste.

What makes a brand a winner is the perception that it is the market leader. It's a battle of perception rather than a battle of product quality.

As the market leader in high-end coffee, Starbucks is perceived to be better than all other coffee brands.

In an emerging category with many brands fighting for a share of the consumer's mind, the brand that gets in the mind first and establishes a leadership position is almost impossible to dislodge. (Whether or not the brand was actually first is irrelevant.)

Kleenex in tissue. Heinz in ketchup. Hellmann's in mayonnaise.

Take the issue of words versus visuals. Words are weak. They're not very memorable and they lack credibility. Conversely, visual hammers are strong, memorable and emotional.

It's odd. Exaggeration works in visuals, but seldom works in verbals. "Ralph Lauren is the brand that polo players wear," would generate nothing but yawns among consumers.

On the other hand, the polo-player visual symbol which communicates exactly the same thing is a powerful device. It says that Ralph Lauren is the upscale brand, the leader in the category.

After all, next to yacht racing, polo is probably the world's most expensive sport, played mostly by millionaires and royalty.

What does the alligator say about the Lacoste brand?

Nothing, except that the brand is Lacoste. In essence, the alligator is a rebus, a picture that stands for a word. The polo player is a hammer that identifies Ralph Lauren as the market leader.

Visuals are powerful because people tend to believe what they see and are skeptical of what they hear. Typical remark: “I know it’s true, I saw it with my own eyes.”

A hammer creates visibility for a brand far beyond what can be achieved by words alone.

Consider Rolls-Royce automobiles. Rolls-Royce does almost no advertising in the American market and it gets little publicity. Yet the brand is well-known and is often considered the best automobile brand in the world.

And it’s not because America is being overrun by Rolls-Royce wheels. In 2011, only 348 of them were sold in the U.S. market. Yet the grille of a Rolls is an unrivaled visual hammer. Even though the average consumer sees very few Rolls-Royces each year, the few that he or she does see make a lasting impression.

When you notice that unique grille, you don’t say, what car is that? You say, that’s a Rolls.

(That same year, 2011, there were 250,426 Mazda vehicles sold in America. How many Mazdas do you remember seeing on the road? No visual hammer and your brand becomes almost invisible.)

Porsche, Ferrari and Mini Cooper have taken the same approach as Rolls. Design a visual difference into the product and then maintain that

difference over decades, not years.

Take the hybrid vehicle. There are some 25 hybrid models on the American market, but one brand, the Prius, has a dominant share.

In a recent year, the Toyota Prius had 51 percent of the market.

Compare Honda with Toyota. Since 2002, the company has been selling the Honda Civic Hybrid in competition with the Toyota Prius.

In nine years, consumers have bought four times as many Prius hybrids as Civic hybrids.

Honda Civic hybrid.

Why the difference? The Prius is a visual hammer. It looks like a hybrid, meaning that it looks totally different than any other automobile on the road. Smaller and quirkier, too. The Honda Civic hybrid looks exactly like a Honda Civic.

In other words, it looks like all the other Honda Civics on the highway. In my neighborhood, there a Honda Civic hybrid with the vanity license plate “HYBRID.” People don’t just want a hybrid, they also want a car that looks like a hybrid.

The other half of the equation is the name “Prius,” which is the verbal name that gets hammered in the mind by the unique visual.

The Honda Civic hybrid has no visual hammer and no verbal nail.

Recently, Toyota announced that it would drop the Toyota name from the Prius and set it up as a separate brand. A good idea that will further hammer the Prius nail and its leadership position into consumers’ minds.

Look at the current move into electric cars by almost every major automotive company. The first two to hit the road are the Chevrolet Volt

and the Nissan Leaf.

Have you seen the new Nissan Leaf? They will be hard to see because production is limited and they look the same as every other small car.

It's way too late to redesign the vehicle, but what Nissan could have done is to produce all of its Leafs for the first year or so in a single color.

"Electric green" would be my choice.

A simple step like this would have cost nothing but would have greatly increased "street visibility" for the Nissan Leaf brand. And with a name like "Leaf" what better color to use than green.

As far as a single color is concerned, you might think that "early adopters" would complain about the lack of choice. But I doubt it. Why did they buy a Leaf in the first place? It's not to save money; it's to make a statement. "Look at me. I care about the environment."

A distinctive color would make the statement even more dramatic.

You can also have negative visual hammers. Take the Smart car which was introduced in the American market in 2008.

Initially, the vehicle received a blast of favorable publicity. Easy to drive, easy to park, good gas mileage. The first year the Smart car was on the market, 24,622 vehicles were sold.

Then Smart sales plummeted. To 14,595 vehicles the second year. And just 5,927 vehicles the third year. And 5,208 the fourth year.

It's easy to figure out what happened to Smart. Its street visibility was bound to create a lot of negative comments and criticism.

“Why pay full price for half a car?” Or “what did it look like before it was rear-ended by an 18-wheeler?”

You can sometimes look too different. It’s not just what prospects think of your product; it’s also what everybody else thinks of your product, too.

Social pressure, which has been amplified even more by social media, plays an important role in what products and brands consumers buy or don’t buy.

People make statements with the brands they choose. And when they choose a brand they often want everybody to know what that brand is.

But in some categories, it’s difficult to create a visual difference. You could make a man’s dress shirt look different, but what man would want to wear it?

Instead, Ralph Lauren put the polo player on his shirts, the first dress shirts to carry a commercial message. Then he made a really bold move and eliminated the pocket, saving money and adding a touch of difference to his shirts.

Sometimes you can make a product look different by doing the same thing, subtracting something.

Years ago, the creator of a candy-mint product contracted with a manufacturer to press the mints into shape. But the manufacturer found the pressing process worked much better with a hole in the middle.

Hence the brand name Life Savers and the verbal slogan “The candy mint with the hole.”

A short time later, Life Savers was the No.1 mint-candy brand in America, a position it has held in the marketplace ever since.

With such a mighty hammer, you might think it would be easy to take the Life Savers brand into other categories like gum and fruit punch.

As an executive of the candy company said at the time: “Our consumer dialogue indicates that the Life Savers brand name conveys more than

merely ‘candy with the hole.’ It also means excellence in flavor, outstanding value and dependable quality.”

Not so. Life Savers chewing gum, Life Savers fruit punch and other Life Savers line extensions are long gone, leaving Life Savers as “the candy mint with the hole.”

Even a product called “Life Savers Holes” was a total disaster.

A visual hammer is not a sledge hammer. It’s more like an upholstery hammer with a narrow head. It allows Life Savers to get away with selling Gummy Savers, the gummy candy with a hole.

But the hammer is not big enough to save a product called Life Savers Holes.

What Life Savers did in candy, Cheerios has done in breakfast cereal. Most cereals are flakes of wheat, corn, oats or bran. Distinguishable from one another on the outside of the box, but not in the bowl.

Not Cheerios, practically the only brand you can recognize in a bowl twenty feet away. “The cereal with the hole” is the brand’s visual hammer which differentiates Cheerios from hundreds of other breakfast cereals, most of them visually similar.

So it should come as no surprise that Cheerios is the No.1 cereal brand, selling one out of every eight boxes of cereal sold in supermarkets, twice the market share of the No.2 brand, Kellogg’s Special K.

Another dominant brand using a “holes” strategy is Thomas’ English muffins.

"The Original Nooks & Crannies English Muffins" is the verbal nail that exploits both the authenticity of the brand and its differentiation. The English stagecoach also hammers that verbal nail.

Then there was a shoe with the brand name "Beach." The shoes had holes for ventilation and drainage.

Thank goodness they abandoned the Beach name and renamed the shoes "Crocs," a brand which caught on quickly and developed a loyal and vociferous following.

"People would say Man, those are ugly," said Crocs founder Duke Hanson, "and we would say, you just got to try them on."

Eventually that became a verbal nail for the brand: "Ugly can be beautiful."

The rise of Crocs was spectacular. From almost nothing in 2002 to $847.4 million in sales (and $168.2 million in net profits) five years later.

The fall of Crocs was just as spectacular as its rise. In 2008 and 2009, Crocs lost $229.2 million on sales of $1.4 billion.

It was a classic case of "too much, too soon." Not only did Crocs flood the market with a rainbow of colors, it quickly added many other styles: flip-flops, sandals and even ladies heels. Especially troublesome was the

fact that many of the expanded styles were meant to be attractive and fashionable, which undercut the brand's verbal nail, "Ugly can be beautiful."

In addition, Crocs spent millions buying up other companies like EXO Italia which made vinyl shoes and Fury Hockey which made sticks, gloves, pants and elbow pads. There was even talk of launching Crocs clothing. (Holes in clothing?)

Fortunately, most of these line extensions were liquidated and in 2010 Crocs became profitable again with net income of $67.7 million on sales of $789.7 million.

Even the tiniest of holes can also serve as the source for a visual hammer.

A brand with a fantastic track record is Geox, the shoe that breathes. Currently the company sells more than $1 billion worth every year. Even more spectacular is its profit margins, which over the past five years have been averaging about 14 percent a year.

Geox is a very good example of the power of a verbal/visual approach to building a brand.

If you just focused on the benefits of the Geox brand, you might come up with a slogan like "The healthiest, most comfortable athletic shoe you can buy."

That says it all, right?

It sure does, but it rules out the possibility of a visual hammer.

How do you visualize "healthiest" and "most comfortable?" You can't.

But "the shoe that breathes" lends itself to a dramatic visual.

Notice, too, that without the visual, the verbal claim would fall totally flat.

"A shoe that breathes? That's ridiculous. Shoes don't breathe."

(The right visual is often incredibly effective because many consumers will accept visually what they would instantly reject verbally.)

Reebok recently introduced a new shoe technology that is creating a lot of interest among consumers. Called “ZigTech,” the footwear utilizes a unique “zig-zag” geometry that propels the runner forward and reduces muscle fatigue.

It’s a great visual hammer that is getting lost in a blizzard of confusing words. The technology is called “ZigTech,” the design of the shoes is called “zig-zag,” the latest extension is the “ZigTech Nano” and the marketing program is called “ReeZig – More energy.” A better approach might have been to launch a new brand based on ZigTech.

Visual hammers are particularly effective for high-end fashion products. They tell friends and relatives how smart (or how dumb) you are. Take ultra-expensive Louis Vuitton handbags. They have a unique multiple-logotype design that anyone can recognize on the street.

In certain circles, owning a Louis Vuitton handbag is one of those possessions a woman just has to have. In Tokyo, according to one report, more than 90 percent of women in their twenties own a Louis Vuitton handbag.

If the handbag itself weren’t quite so “outlandish,” Louis Vuitton sales wouldn’t be nearly as high.

Sure, products should be attractive, but it’s even more important that they be distinctive, as the success of Louis Vuitton, Crocs and other brands demonstrates.

In Interbrand’s latest report, Louis Vuitton is the world’s 16th most valuable brand, worth $21.9 billion. The 44th most valuable brand in the

world is Gucci, another example of a brand with a potent hammer.

As a matter of fact, two hammers, a luxury that few brands can afford. Red-and-green stripes and a double-G interlock trademark.

Each of the Gucci hammers do well, but what about a verbal nail?

Both Gucci and Louis Vuitton would benefit from verbal expressions of their luxury positions. But these are not easy to develop.

Pick up a copy of Vogue and study the fashion ads. Like this Gucci ad, you'll find most of them totally visual, with the copy limited to the name of the brand. There's an excellent opportunity to "break the fashion pattern" by developing a verbal nail that could be visualized.

That's what Barack Obama did in 2008. His Presidential election campaign captured the attention of the marketing community.

At the Association of National Advertisers conference that year, Barack Obama was voted "Marketer of the Year."

His 2008 political campaign combined a memorable nail (Change we can believe in) with a memorable visual hammer, the rising sun.

The combination produced an upset victory that few pundits would have predicted just a year earlier.

For a virtually-unknown first-time senator, a member of a minority group and a man with an unusual name to be elected President of the United States is a testament to the effectiveness of the hammer-and-nail marketing approach.

But the questions arises, what should Barack Obama's 2012 campaign focus on? It shouldn't be "Change." Why is this so?

Because the incumbent always has an advantage. As the old saying goes, Better the devil you know (than the devil you don't.) Obama needs to stress his leadership in engineering an economy that is "built to last." In other words, the job is half done.

Or as he said in his State of the Union speech, "We've come too far to turn back now." Therefore using the 2008 symbol without the change theme is a good direction.

Even better would be the verbal nail: "We've come too far to turn back now."

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 6

PACKAGE

MAKE IT DIFFERENT.

Most brands are focused on product. The emphasis is on developing and producing a product that is demonstrably superior to the competition.

Packaging is often overlooked as a branding element. Sure, the package itself is loaded with copy explaining the virtues of the brand. But the actual package, its shape and its composition can be an important visual element.

Too often package design is delegated to manufacturing experts who crave efficiency, cost and utility. Hellmann's is a good example. It's the leading mayonnaise brand but the packaging is mediocre at best. Hellmann's looks just like every other mayonnaise jar on the shelf.

On the other hand, Heinz ketchup is an example of how innovative packaging can help build a dominant brand.

Its unique glass bottle with its octagon shape is instantly recognized by most consumers. It's almost as well-known as Coke's contour bottle.

Even high-end white-table-cloth restaurants will often put Heinz ketchup bottles on their tables, one of the few food brands that get treated this way.

For years, Heinz was marketed as “The slowest ketchup in the West,” one of the most effective verbal nails ever developed.

According to the company, Heinz ketchup exits its iconic glass bottle at .028 miles per hour. If the viscosity of the ketchup is greater than this speed, the ketchup is rejected for sale.

Currently, Heinz is marketing larger-size plastic ketchup bottles which presumably can be sold for lower prices. But like Coca-Cola and its contour bottle, the Heinz octagon bottle remains an important visual hammer for the brand, even though relatively few are sold.

How would you make a pair of pantyhose look different? (Most women want them to look invisible.)

If you can’t make your product look different, you can still make its package look different.

Years ago, Hanes Corporation marketed Hanes, the leading brand of pantyhose. But the Hanes brand was sold in department stores only and the corporation wanted a second brand for supermarkets and mass merchandisers.

The name it picked was brilliant and the packaging (the visual hammer) was even better.

The double-entendre “L’eggs” was an almost perfect name for a pantyhose sold in supermarkets. And the plastic-egg package was a killer hammer.

L’eggs was so successful it became the country’s largest-selling pantyhose brand. But apparently the plastic-egg packaging was expensive, so at some point in time L’eggs was moved from plastic to cardboard.

That’s not necessarily a bad idea. Launching a new brand is an difficult operation, especially one destined for supermarkets.

(In America, some 17,000 new food products are introduced every year.)

In some categories, it might make sense to launch a new brand in ultra-expensive packaging. Then, after the brand becomes successful, back off

into conventional packaging to keep the brand's price reasonable.

Another category that gets a host of new brands every year is beverages. One recently-successful new beverage brand is Vitaminwater. So successful in fact that in 2007 the Coca-Cola Company bought Glaceau, the maker of Vitaminwater and Smartwater, for $4.1 billion in cash, the company's largest acquisition to date.

The Vitaminwater bottles are perhaps the most visually-arresting beverage packages ever conceived. They remind me of a row of prescription drugs on a pharmacy's shelf, which is exactly the right concept for a "vitamin" beverage.

Whether or not the Vitaminwater brand is worth $4.1 billion is another matter, but you have to admire the brand's visual hammer.

But beware. While the Vitaminwater bottle was designed to look symbolically like a bottle of vitamins, that's exactly the wrong strategy to use if you're not first.

If you're not first in a new category, you want to design your bottle so it looks like the bottle doesn't belong in the category at all.

Take vodka, one of the oldest alcoholic beverages. Some Polish vodka brands go back centuries, notable Zubrowka and Starka from the 16th century and Goldwasser from the early 17th century.

Compared to these and a number of Russian brands, Absolut from Sweden is an infant, not introduced until the spring of 1979.

In spite of its late start, the Absolut bottle would become one of the most famous visual hammers in the world. Instead of designing Absolut to

look like a vodka bottle, the designers made it look like an apothecary jar you'd find in a pharmacy.

Swedish advertising executive Gunnar Broman brought the bottle and the proposed name to ad agency N.W. Ayer for its help in advertising the new vodka.

"It looks like one of those medical bottles," was the first response of the Americans. "Like for blood plasma or something." Another chimed in, 'You can't sell a thing like that. Well, you might be able to sell it to doctors."

Eventually the account ended up at TBWA which made the Absolut bottle the star of a long-running advertising campaign which has won many awards.

Typical advertising headlines: "Absolut attraction." And: "Absolut perfection." And: "Absolut treasure."

How effective was the bottle advertising? Absolut became the No.1 imported vodka in America and one of the ten best-selling distilled-spirit brands in the world.

Advertising Age selected the Absolut "bottle" campaign as one of the top 100 advertising campaigns of the 20th century. (No.7.)

If the bottle was the hammer, what was Absolut's verbal nail? In my opinion, it was Absolut's high price. Compared to Smirnoff, the leading vodka and the largest-selling spirit brand in America, Absolut was some 70 percent more expensive.

That's a big price difference for a product which by law must be "colorless, tasteless and odorless."

But why didn't Absolut mention its higher price in its advertising? In truth, there's no easy way to say "more expensive" without sounding gauche.

Furthermore, vodka drinkers will get the high-price message as soon as they buy a bottle of Absolut in a liquor store or order an Absolut martini in a restaurant.

Another thing. Why are so many visual hammers developed by startups and so few developed by large companies?

Where are the visual hammers for big brands like IBM, Xerox, Hewlett-Packard, General Electric, Verizon, Intel, Nokia, Toyota, Cisco, Oracle and AT&T?

When a big company owns a visual hammer, it's usually because it was a legacy hammer created several generations back. The Mercedes Tri-Star. The Rolex watchband. The Campbell's soup can.

Big companies don't usually make big marketing decisions without first conducting extensive research. And consumers don't like anything that's too different.

"We spent $65,000 on research and it was quite negative," said Michel Roux, president of the U.S. company that was planning to import Absolut.

"It said the bottle would be lost on the shelf, the name was nothing like vodka and Sweden was not seen as a vodka-producing country."

As a psychological principle, consumers like "better," but they don't like "different." As a marketing principle, "better" doesn't work, but "different" does.

If you can't make the bottle different, maybe you can make the glass the product is served in different.

That's the strategy employed by Stella Artois when it arrived in the American market back in 1999.

To introduce the new beer brand, Interbrew, the Belgian brewer of Stella Artois, limited distribution to the 20 most-exclusive bars and clubs in Manhattan.

Furthermore, they charged almost 20 percent more for a keg than its Holland competitor did for a keg of Heineken.

That took courage since Stella is the Bud of Belgium, so ordinary fast-food restaurants sell it in plastic cups.

No plastic cups for Stella Artois in the U.S. market. Interbrew provided the bars with its unique, gold-tipped chalice glasses and a lesson

in Stella etiquette. Beer was to be served between 36 and 38 degrees F. and the foam must be shaved off with a spoon.

(Actually the Stella glasses were no special deal. In Belgium, every beer has its own unique glass designed to highlight the brand's special flavor, and Stella Artois is no exception.)

With its chalice hammer, Stella Artois sales took off. The brand was expanded into national distribution and eventually into supermarkets and other retail outlets. Some Stella cans even feature its unique chalice glass.

Today, Stella Artois is one of the top ten imported-beer brands in America.

What's missing from the Stella story is the verbal nail. Its current position, "Perfection has its price," adequately describes the brand, but at the cost of memorability and distinction.

That's a potential problem for Stella Artois, Absolut, Corona and many other brands with strong visual hammers and weak verbal nails.

Because the strength of a hammer is partially based on its shock value, a hammer over time slowly loses some of its marketing effectiveness.

The reverse is true for a verbal nail. Unless you are using one of the seven words you can't use on network television, it's hard to find any combination of words that will have the shock value of an arresting visual.

One exception might be French Connection. In 2001, the company began branding its clothes in the United Kingdom as "fcuk."

Apparently it discovered the acronym when a fax was sent from its Hong Kong store to its United Kingdom outlet entitled "FCHK to FCUK."

Though the company insists that FCUK was an acronym for French Connection United Kingdom, its similarity to a certain other word caused considerable controversy. French Connection exploited the controversy by producing a popular range of T-shirts with messages such as: “fcuk fashion,” “fcuk football,” “fcuk on the beach.”

Unlike visual hammers, verbal nails actually become more credible as time passes. Initially, consumers are skeptical of claims like “the ultimate driving machine.”

But over time, and with repeated repetitions, the credibility of a verbal claim actually increases.

The first time you heard Nike’s slogan “Just do it,” you probably thought, Huh. What do they mean by that?

But eventually, “Just do it” because more than a tagline. It became a rallying cry for the younger generation. The more people who identify with a slogan, the more powerful that slogan becomes.

Marketers make a major mistake when they copy-test verbal slogans before using them. It doesn’t matter what a consumer’s first reaction is. What matters is how he or she will feel after they have heard the slogan 50 or 100 times.

But how can you know in advance how they might feel? You can’t. But one useful rule of thumb is to make sure the visual is strongly linked to the nail.

Marketing is like woodworking. No matter how good your hammer is, you have to consistently hit your nail in order to make your brand successful.

The Stella glass is a great hammer, but it has little connection with the nail, “Perfection has its price.”

Sure, you can get the connection if you think about it. Expensive glass equals expensive beer which is the price you pay for perfection.

But to work, the connection has to be instantaneous, with no time left for thinking. To work, the Stella verbal needs to use the word “glass” or something similar in its verbal nail.

Notice the difference between the Stella Artois glass and the Evian "mountains." The mountains are more than a nice visual to decorate the label. The mountains are the hammer and the "Natural spring water from the French Alps" is the nail.

It's the combination of the two, the mountain hammer and the French Alps nail, that has made Evian the world's best-selling expensive water.

One of the most unusual packaging hammers is the swing-top cap on Grolsch Premium Pilsner which looks both expensive and also obsolete. Yet it's one of the reasons why Grolsch is the 21st largest producer of beer in the world and second only to Heineken in Holland, its home country. Like the Jack Daniel's bottle, the Grolsch swing-top cap connotes authenticity and old-fashioned quality.

Too bad Grolsch doesn't nail a verbal idea along with its swing-top hammer.

Still, Grolsch was bought by SABMiller back in 2007 for $1.2 billion. Not bad for an old-fashioned beer brand.

An old-fashioned packaging concept that has created a stir in the distilled-spirits business is the dripping red-wax seal on Maker's Mark bourbon.

Not only is the redwax seal distinctive, it's also a legal trademark for the brand. The dripping red wax is the hammer, but what's the verbal nail?

It's the name, Maker's Mark, which communicates the idea that its bourbon is handcrafted by artisans.

Marker’s Mark has experienced 31 years of double-digit growth and claims a 70-percent market share in the fine-bourbon category.

Another packaging visual hammer is wrapping the brand in paper bound by gold tape.

That’s what Lea & Perrins did with its Worcestershire sauce brand which has a reported 97-percent share.

What’s the nail? It’s the word “original” on the package which together with the brand’s dominant market share reinforces the position of Lea & Perrins as the leader in the category.

When a brand has such an elevated market share, it is almost immune to competition.

(What’s true in Worcestershire sauce is also true in personal-computer operating systems. For decades, Windows has had a 90-percent market share.)

Pom Wonderful is doing the same thing with pomegranate juice. With a shape unlike any other ever seen, the Pom Wonderful bottle is truly unique and different.

One particularly effective billboard for the Pom Wonderful brand has the bottle dressed with a superhero’s cape.

The verbal nail: “The antioxidant superpower.”

That sounds like a slogan that could last a lifetime.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 7

ACTION

MORE EFFECTIVE THAN STILLS.

There's no question that visual hammers involving action, movement or demonstration are more effective than static hammers, or still pictures.

And the advertising medium that can best handle "action" is television.

That's one reason why television has continued to prosper while print and radio have declined. In 2010, for example, more money was spent on TV advertising than on newspapers, magazines and radio advertising combined.

Dove soap, for example, is one-fourth moisturizing lotion. Years ago, a typical print ad tried to exploit this feature with a photo of a woman in a bathtub and the slogan "Dove creams your skin while you wash."

But it was television that built the Dove brand into the market leader, with its current 24-percent share of the bar-soap market.

And what visual hammered the Dove brand into consumers' minds? The action of a hand pouring moisturizing lotion into a bar of Dove soap.

Utterly simple, incredibly effective.

What's the difference between saying "one-fourth moisturizing lotion" and demonstrating it?

Nothing. Both the verbal and the visual communicate exactly the same idea. The difference is memorability.

The average person reads or hears about 42,000 words every day.

How many of those 42,000 words do most people remember? Very few. Furthermore, they don't necessarily believe many of the words they do hear or read.

A television visual demonstration, especially one that contains an element of shock, is not only memorable, it's believable.

A visual "shock" isn't necessarily something as dramatic as parting the Red Sea. Television, for example, is an intimate medium. Johnny Carson used to get a big laugh by raising his eyebrows. And today Jon Stewart or Stephen Colbert can do the same thing.

As TV moves to high definition and the sets get bigger and bigger, the potential for subtlety increases.

A visual "shock" can also be achieved by the juxtapositioning of elements. Pouring a cup of moisturizing lotion into a bar of soap creates visual tension or shock.

Is a Mini Cooper a shocking vehicle? Not really, it's just another small car. Is a Ford Excursion a shocking vehicle? Not really, it's just another big sport-utility vehicle.

In 2002, when BMW introduced the Mini Cooper in the American market, it put a number of Minis on top of Ford Excursions and drove them around city roads and streets.

Headline: "What are you doing for fun this weekend?"

Another example of juxtapositioning is Tropicana's "straw in the orange." Neither a straw nor an orange is visually shocking, but the combination is.

It’s especially so on TV where the viewer can see a person sticking a straw into an orange and then drinking from it.

You can’t get juice out of an orange by sucking on a straw, you might be thinking. True, but a visual can have emotional power whether it’s true or not. The viewer thinks, Tropicana contains the juice of whole oranges because it’s “not from concentrate.”

Just as shocking is the brand’s market share. Although Tropicana’s “not from concentrate” brand is premium priced, its market share is about 30 percent.

Recently, however, Tropicana decided to drop the “straw in the orange” visual hammer on its packaging and focus on a verbal approach.

Along with its new approach came a new package design without the straw. The new campaign was based on the word “squeeze.”

The president of Tropicana North America, as reported in The New York Times, explained the concept: “The whole idea of squeeze is to play up the functional benefit of orange juice in providing fruit for people’s daily diets and the emotional connection people have with Tropicana.”

“Squeeze” added the chairman of Tropicana’s advertising agency, “is the process by which we get our product and the hug.”

“There was this notion of owning a simple word that would communicate the love, the care, in the Obama moment we’re all going through,” added the chairman.

This is typical left-brain verbal thinking, totally focused on the rational power of words to incite emotion instead of the inherently-emotional power of visuals.

What visual would you use to illustrate the word “squeeze?” A consumer hugging an orange? I think not.

As most people know, consumer reaction to the new Tropicana campaign was swift and vicious.

I’ve never seen such an outpouring of negative comments. In two months, sales dropped 20 percent.

The negative reaction was so swift and dramatic that Tropicana dropped the new packaging and brought back the “straw in the orange.”

Actually, Tropicana came up with two visual hammers. The straw in the orange and a zipper that symbolically opens on the carton to allow 16 fresh-picked oranges to jump inside the Tropicana package.

Both are nice visuals, but are two hammers better than one? I think not. They just create visual confusion.

Another emotionally-potent visual hammer is the yellow pages logo with the verbal nail “let your fingers do the walking.” Again, the walking fingers were particularly effective on television, although most of the usage of the symbol was in print.

Today, of course, Google has just about killed the market for yellow-page advertising as more and more consumers use their fingers to do their searching online rather than on yellow pages.

Google built its brand with a clean white page and a search box. Nothing fancy and always the same.

But a few days of the year, Google changes its logotype to celebrate special occasions, like the Fourth of July.

The images used to be static, but recently Google has been using subtle “action” within some holiday logos to dramatize those special occasions.

This “action” idea would probably never occur to the business executives who are highly verbal. They think in words, not pictures. They assume the two are interchangeable.

To communicate the essence of a visual, one just needs to verbalize it.

Not true. A visual activates the right side of your brain, the emotional side. A verbal activates the left side of your brain, the rational side.

Aleve has developed a great hammer (one bottle of Aleve equals four bottles of Tylenol Extra) and a great nail (If you could take fewer pills, why wouldn’t you?) But they are using the nail primarily in print.

On television, Aleve uses “slice of life” commercials where users talk about the benefits of Aleve instead of demonstrating them with a powerful visual hammer.

Seeing two Aleve pills compared to eight Tylenol pills effectively demonstrates the difference, perhaps even more so than does the bottle

comparison. The more specific you can be the better. “Just 2 Aleve have the strength to relieve pain all day.”

Perhaps no series of television commercials have demonstrated the power of a visual hammer like the Marlboro commercials in the 1960s.

All cowboys, all horses, all action, few words.

The Marlboro music, the theme from the motion picture the Magnificent Seven starring Yul Brynner and Steve McQueen, also contributed to the emotional effectiveness of the spots.

Music doesn’t lie dormant, frozen in time, like the words on a page. Music is aural action. It’s always moving, going someplace. At times in a hurry, at times at a languid pace. But always in motion.

It’s the difference between a sheet of music and music itself.

The 1971 ban on televised tobacco advertising put an end to the Marlboro commercials.

But today they are still worth studying to understand the emotional effectiveness of a television visual hammer augmented with a musical theme.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 8

FOUNDER

NATURAL-BORN HAMMERS.

We live in a celebrity-obsessed world. The media is fascinated with the lives of the rich and famous. Even ordinary people can become celebrities as long as they are infamous.

The most successful magazine in America is not a news magazine, a sports magazine or a financial magazine.

It’s a celebrity magazine, People, which carries more advertising pages than any other magazine.

Don’t blame the media. It’s the consumers who buy the fan magazines and flock to the television shows like Celebrity Apprentice, Jersey Shore or Keeping up the Kardashians that should get the credit or the blame for our obsession with celebrities.

Even business tycoons are getting their share of publicity. It’s surprising how many corporate CEOs are getting to be just as famous as their companies.

Michael Dell of Dell, Howard Schultz of Starbucks, Steve Ballmer of Microsoft, Richard Branson of Virgin, Larry Ellison of Oracle, Jeff Immelt of General Electric, Mark Zuckerberg of Facebook. And, of course, Donald Trump.

If you want to make your company famous, we often advise our clients, then you also have to make your chief executive famous too.

The founder of a company benefits from this celebrity worship in two ways: (1) Everyone wants to know something about the person who runs a company and (2) Everyone assumes the products and service of that company reflects the values of its founder. When you are both, as Steve Jobs was, the PR potential is doubled.

Celebrity worship is a relatively new development, but founder worship is not. Henry Ford founded the Ford Motor Company more than a century ago and the company still uses his signature as its trademark.

Why would a modern corporation with the marketing goal of trying to establish a reputation for the latest in automotive technology still use as its logotype the old-fashioned signature of Henry Ford, its founder?

Doesn’t it make the company look out of date?

Perhaps. But the old-fashioned signature also provides both legitimacy and continuity. Any company that has been around as long as the Ford Motor Company must be doing something right.

The concept of legitimacy is especially important in industries that sell “invisible” products. What do you get when you buy a life insurance policy?

You might spend thousands of dollars a year and have nothing to show for it except a pile of paper.

The legitimacy and financial stability of the insurance company is an important aspect of your purchase.

That’s why in the year 1862 the founders of a Boston insurance company borrowed the name of one of the 56 signers of the Declaration of Independence.

Today, John Hancock Financial Services is a major American insurance company, although currently owned by a Canadian company. Of the 56 signers, John Hancock is one of the most famous and you can see why.

Hancock’s large, flamboyant signature (nearly five inches wide) dwarfs the other 55 signers.

Imagine that? A visual hammer on the Declaration of Independence.

Jack Daniel’s is the best-selling whiskey in the world and the fourth best-selling liquor brand in America (after Smirnoff, Bacardi and Captain Morgan rum.)

One reason for its success is that Jack Daniel’s whiskey is old. The distillery was founded in 1866, just after the Civil War, the first one licensed in the country.

Every category is different, but in the beverage category, old is good, not bad. Witness the success of brands like Old Grand-Dad, Old Crow and Olde English.

And witness the failure of New Coke. Once a beverage brand has become established, change is only going to cause confusion among consumers.

In all types of beverages, it’s not enough to be old. You also need to communicate the concept that the brand has never changed.

Jack Daniel's has done that in various ways including such messages as: "Not subject to change. Not now. Not ever."

But it's the black label itself that's the visual hammer. The label looks old and the old-fashioned look is reinforced with the words: "Old Time. Old No. 7 brand."

On the back of the label is the message: "Whiskey made as our fathers made it for 7 generations."

Jack Daniel's has also managed to portray the town of Lynchburg, Tennessee, where the distillery is located, as old and never changing.

As one advertisement said: "Jack Daniel's. Enjoyed in 135 countries, made in a town with one stoplight."

Jack Daniel, the founder, and the black label are the visual hammers and the "first American whiskey" is the verbal nail although, like Marlboro, the verbal idea is not stated explicitly.

Obviously there are a lot of less-successful liquor brands trying to create an old-fashioned look and reputation. But it's not enough to have an old-fashioned label and an old-fashioned name like Ancient Age bourbon. You also need an old-fashioned hammer.

Compare Yuengling beer to Jack Daniel's whiskey. D.G. Yuengling & Son of Pottsville, Pennsylvania, was founded in 1829, more than three decades before Mr. Daniel started his distillery.

While Jack Daniel's is the largest-selling whiskey, Yuengling doesn't make the top 20 in beer.

The name "Yuengling," an Anglicized version of the German term for "young man," is weak. And unfortunately, the name doesn't sound German.

Nor in English does it connote much of anything or sound very nice. The verbal nail “America’s oldest brewery” has potential, but not without a strong hammer, which the brand definitely lacks. In 2010, President Barack Obama sent a case of Yuengling to Canadian Prime Minister Stephen Harper to cover a friendly wager on the outcome of the Winter Olympic hockey final.

That’s the kind of endorsement and PR the brand is going to need to pump up sales. But it’s not going to be easy with a name like Yuengling and no visual hammer.

If Yuengling beer is a bad name, how about John Schnatter’s pizza?

Fortunately, Mr. Schnatter chose a different name. He called his chain, “Papa John’s” in order to compete with Pizza Hut, Domino’s and Little Caesars.

And he has done extremely well. In the American market, Papa John’s has the highest annual per-unit sales of any chain in the pizza category.

Here are per-unit sales in 2010.

Compared to its competitors, Papa John’s went upscale with a verbal nail it has used consistently for decades.

“Better ingredients. Better pizza.”

But the visual hammer in the television commercials is the real secret of Papa John’s success.

With a name like Papa John, you would expect to see an older, Italian-looking man with grey hair and a handlebar mustache in the commercials.

What you don’t expect to see is John Schnatter, who looks like a clean-shaven college student with a rah-rah enthusiasm for his brand.

Papa John is the visual hammer. He looks different than what you might expect. That’s what creates the visual shock which hammers in the verbal nail. “Better ingredients. Better pizza. Papa John’s.”

A good picture, someone once said, would be a row of West Point cadets lined up perfectly. A great picture would be that same line-up with a pigeon sitting on the shoulder of one of the cadets. The pigeon is the hammer that creates the visual shock.

Nobody looked as shocking as Harland Sanders, founder of Kentucky Fried Chicken, now KFC.

Better known as Colonel Sanders, he traveled the country in a white suit and black string tie promoting his secret recipe of 11 herbs and spices. “Finger lickin’ good” was the verbal nail and Sanders was the visual hammer.

The combination created the largest chicken chain in the country.

Harland Sanders was a real Kentucky Colonel, the highest award given to individuals by the state.

(Other Kentucky Colonels include Elvis Presley, Bill Clinton, Betty White and Tiger Woods.)

For a number of years KFC has struggled with its marketing and its product offering. “Fried” chicken developed a perception as unhealthy, which was the reason for switching to the KFC initials.

But unless a company or brand is exceptionally well-known (IBM, AT&T, GE and a handful of others), it's usually a mistake to change a brand's name to initials.

Sure, KFC is a well-known nickname for the brand, but the initials just serve as short-hand for Kentucky Fried Chicken in the mind. It is very hard to run away from what you stand for. And KFC stands for "fried chicken."

KFC has also been running from one ad campaign to another with little continuity or success.

What's wrong with all of these slogans? None of them suggest a visual.

And without a visual, almost any campaign is doomed from the start.

(Colonel Sanders is on the building, but he no longer serves as the visual hammer for KFC's marketing.)

"So good," is KFC's latest loser slogan. It's a good example of tunnel thinking, equivalent to putting "blinders" on a race horse.

"So good" might be a minimally effective marketing slogan except one thing. Too many other brands have used similar slogans.

- Campbell's soup ....."M'm..M'm good."
- Maxwell House ....."Good to the last drop."
- Delta ....."Good goes around."
- GE ....."We bring good things to life."

Both visuals and verbals need to be unique and different. "Good" is a worn-out word.

Except, of course, for those brands that have pre-empted the "good" concept including Campbell's soup and, would you believe, Kentucky Fried Chicken whose original slogan was "Finger-lickin' good."

So how do you fix a brand that has lost its way?

The best way is to back track. Go back in history to reclaim aspects of the brand that made it successful in the first place.

One visual aspect of the KFC brand that almost every consumer identifies with is Colonel Sanders in his white suit and white goatee.

The best brands are those where every aspect of the brand is “locked” together, which, of course, is what this book is all about.

The locking together of the visual and the verbal. But that concept also applies to the name.

Drive past a KFC restaurant and what do you see? A big picture of Colonel Sanders. So why wouldn’t you call the restaurant chain “Colonel Sanders” chicken?

That locks the brand name to the visual hammer. And why wouldn’t you bring back the original slogan, “Finger-lickin’ good….with 11 herbs and spices?” I would.

One advantage of using a dead founder like Colonel Sanders as your visual hammer is the fact that he will never get into a scandal and damage the brand.

That’s not always the case with a live founder.

What about Martha Stewart who spent five months in jail for “obstructing justice, conspiracy and making false statements” in an insider-trading case.

Did the bad publicity hurt the Martha Stewart brand? In the short term, sure, but it didn’t kill it.

The brand today is probably no better off or worse off that it was before the trial.

That’s not to say that the brand is healthy. It’s not.

In the last ten years, Martha Stewart Living Omnimedia, the company controlled by Ms. Stewart, had revenues of $2.6 billion and managed to lose $173 million.

Why is the company in such trouble when Martha Stewart is one of the best-known women in America?

That's the paradox of marketing. It doesn't matter how "well-known" you are. The only thing that matters is "what" you are well-known for.

Colonel Sanders is known for chicken. Papa John is known for pizza. Jack Daniel is known for whiskey. John Hancock is known for insurance. But what is Martha Steward known for?

The "Omni" in Martha Stewart Living Omnimedia illustrates the weakness in her brand.

Martha Stewart is known for everything…and nothing. Magazines, books, television, radio, pots & pans, towels, sheets, paint, flowers, you name it.

When you put your name on everything, you usually wind up standing for almost nothing.

Another founder who is floundering is Hugh Hefner of Playboy.

His magazine made an enormous impact when it was first published in December of 1953.

For many years, Playboy was the largest-circulation men's publication in the country. But like Martha Stewart, he couldn't resist the urge to expand his brand.

Over the years there has been Playboy clubs, Playboy hotels, Playboy books, Playboy videos, Playboy cable channels & TV shows and hundreds of Playboy products licensed to various companies including the makers of condoms and t-shirts.

What there hasn't been much of is Playboy profits.

In the past ten years, Hugh Hefner's company, Playboy Enterprises, has had revenues of $3.0 billion and losses of $293 million.

Playboy went public in 1971 for $23.50 a share. It was taken private in 2011 by a group led by Hugh Hefner for $6.15 a share. (After 40 years, not much of a return on your investment.)

In those 40 years, Playboy and its founder Hugh Hefner have received reams of publicity leading people to believe that the company must be fabulously successful.

But PR success is not always equivalent to financial success. Take Richard Branson, founder of Virgin, a megabrand that has spawned 300 different companies worldwide.

Nobody, but nobody, has received as much favorable publicity as Richard Branson.

But PR success is no magic wand that can create instant money. Many of his 300 Virgin companies are reportedly big losers.

Then, too, most Virgin companies are private, so it's hard to tell whether they are successful or not.

But I was able to track down eight of the Virgin companies that reported revenues and profits. (Virgin Active, Virgin Blue, Virgin Media, Virgin Mobile Telecoms, Virgin Money, Virgin Rail, Virgin Unite and Virgin Wine.)

In a recent year, these eight companies reported sales of $10.4 billion and net profits after taxes of …well in total they didn't make any money.

They actually lost $429 million.

Richard Branson is a mighty hammer, but like Martha Stewart and Hugh Hefner he is trying to use his PR skills to hit too many nails at once.

What’s a Virgin anyway? For one thing, it’s an airline. Actually, it’s three airlines, one in the United Kingdom, one in Australia and one in America. None of these three airlines seem to be making any net profits.

Nor do his other Virgin companies appear to be making much progress.

When was the last time you saw someone order a Virgin cola, a Virgin vodka, a Virgin energy shot or unscrew a bottle of Virgin wine?

Yet Branson has had an enormous impact on the marketing community. “If Virgin can do it, why can’t we?”

That’s the attitude of many marketing people worldwide. But few marketing people seem to have dug into the actual results of Virgin’s line extensions. If they did, they would realize it’s not a model to emulate.

Then there’s the question of what happens when Richard Branson is no longer around?

Many visual hammers don’t survive into the second generation. Take Frank Perdue, the man behind the success of Perdue chicken.

In 1953, when Frank Perdue became president and chief executive of Perdue Farms, the chicken-breeding company was doing about $5 million in sales a year.

In 1970, Perdue Farms launched its first television campaign featuring its sharp-featured president.

Sales skyrocketed. By 1988, Perdue revenues reached $975 million. Today, they are $4.6 billion.

While the company has survived and prospered, the tough-man hammer and the tender-chicken nail have not.

In 1994, Frank's son James Perdue took over as the spokesperson for the brand, but he didn't have the tough-guy personality of his father.

Furthermore, his verbal nail, "A healthy obsession with chicken," doesn't have the memorability of "It takes a tough man to make a tender chicken."

Can a personal hammer survive into the second or even the third generation? It certainly can in politics.

Witness the success of George W. Bush, Al Gore, Andrew Cuomo, Chris Dodd, Richard Daley, Ben Quayle and other sons and daughters of famous political fathers. And companies can do the same thing.

But in Perdue's case, perhaps there was too much emphasis on the hammer and not enough on the nail.

A "tender" chicken is a generic claim that could be used by almost any producer.

Perdue chickens had a visual difference that played a big part in the success of the brand.

Perdue chickens were fed marigold leaves to turn their skins bright yellow. Instead of "tender" chicken it might have been better to use "golden" chicken as a verbal nail.

Whenever you have a choice, it's always better to select the claim that is visually different even though it's not verbally better. Visuals are more powerful than words.

No person can live forever, but a founder hammer can exist for several lifetimes. So how does a brand make the transition from a live founder to a dead historical figure?

One thing that is helpful is using a stylized cartoon drawing of the founder rather than a photograph.

That doesn't usually work on television but on signs, on the Internet and in print, it works very well.

Another thing that is helpful is a difference in clothing (white suit & black string tie for Colonel Sanders) or a difference in facial hair (mustache & goatee for Jack Daniel.)

Take Orville Redenbacher, the visual hammer for the popping-corn brand which has survived the death of its founder. It didn't work when they tried to use him as a cartoon on television, but in print, on the Internet and on the package, Orville Redenbacher with his black glasses and bow tie is still alive and well and effective as a visual hammer.

The verbal nail for the brand is its high price. Initially, the words "Gourmet popping corn" were set in larger type than the brand name, followed by the claim, "World's most-expensive popping corn."

Today, the brand is focused on "gourmet." And it doesn't just say gourmet, the brand has a visual difference. Since it only uses larger popping kernels, Orville Redenbacher's popping corn pops bigger and fluffier.

Despite the advantages a higher price can bring, many companies overlook the simple idea of charging more for their products.

That's the idea that built brands like Rolex, Evian, Starbucks, Häagen-Dazs, Grey Goose and many others.

But it's not enough for your brand to be "expensive." Your brand also has to be the first brand in the category to be perceived as expensive.

In marketing terminology, Orville Redenbacher's gourmet popping corn "preempted" the expensive popping-corn category. Other brands that follow might be just as expensive, but they will never become "the" gourmet popping corn.

Another founder that has legs even though he departed the scene in 2008 is Paul Newman, the creator of Newman's Own line of food and beverage products. Since 1982, Newman's Own has contributed over $300 million to charities.

What made Newman such an effective visual hammer was his steely blue eyes and good-humored charm.

What's lacking in most corporate executives today is a sense of humor, which Newman excelled in.

As Newman's Own website says: "Shameless exploitation in pursuit of a common good."

In the corridors of corporate America, nobody talks that way today.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 9

SYMBOLS

VISUALIZING THE INVISIBLE.

A verbal metaphor is a figure of speech in which a word normally used for one thing is applied to another.

"America is a melting pot."

A visual metaphor is a symbol that can help bring an invisible product to life. How do you visualize "insurance," for example? You can't.

That's why insurance companies are big users of visual metaphors or symbols. These symbols can be strong visual hammers.

Travelers uses a red umbrella to symbolize the protection its insurance provides. "It's better under the umbrella" is its latest verbal nail.

The history of the red umbrella demonstrates the enduring power of a visual.

In 1998, in a misguided effort to create a financial supermarket, banking giant Citicorp merged with the Travelers Group.

The combination was called "Citigroup" and it enlisted the red umbrella to symbolize the financial supermarket concept.

The history of conglomerates is a dismal one and Citigroup was no exception. Four years after the merger, Citigroup spun off the Travelers in

an IPO, but kept the valuable red umbrella as part of the Citigroup logotype.

Two years later, Travelers was bought by The St. Paul Companies for $16 billion. The combination was called The St. Paul Travelers Companies.

Consider the situation back at the bank. Citigroup had been using the red umbrella as the symbol for its banking operation for quite a few years and yet the public still thought the umbrella meant “insurance.”

Almost nine years after Citigroup started using the red umbrella as its symbol, it threw in the towel and sold the symbol to The St. Paul Travelers Companies.

Which promptly changed its name to The Travelers Companies.

Chief executive Jay Fishman said at the time: “The recognition of the umbrella to the Travelers name was really quite remarkable.”

When a visual conflicts with a verbal, the visual always wins. Take a picture of a beautiful woman and label the picture “ugly woman.”

The viewer doesn’t believe the woman is ugly but just assumes that somebody put the wrong caption on the picture. Not the wrong picture on the caption.

The visual always dominates the verbal.

The sale of the red umbrella to The Travelers left Citigroup and its other brands including Citibank, CitiFinancial, CitiMortgage, without a visual. So the company created a red “halo” which I assume is supposed to be a highly-symbolic red umbrella. The red halo doesn’t work nearly as well as the Travelers’ red umbrella.

A “red” symbol that works much better than the red halo is the red hat used by Red Hat, Inc.

Red Hat dominates the market for Linux, the open-source computer operating system that is the chief rival to Microsoft's Windows. Linux software is free, but the company makes its money with subscription-based support, training and integration services. In 2010, Red Hat had revenues of $909 million and a net profit margin of 11.8 percent.

Visuals that can be verbalized are much stronger than abstract designs that defy verbal explanations.

Most high-performing sales people are sweet, pleasant and affable individuals. Not Flo, the spokesperson and the visual hammer for the Progressive Insurance brand. "Irritating" is one of the milder things you can say about Flo. As one consumer said: "I wish Flo from Progressive would comb her hair or get a new style...and lighten up the flaming red lipstick."

All of which would make Flo look better, but at the cost of memorability. If your symbol isn't memorable, then your message is probably lost, too.

"Discounts," Progressive's verbal nail, is memorable, too. That's particularly impressive because Flo didn't make her first appearance on television until 2008.

And Progressive Insurance is spending considerably less money than the big three auto insurance companies. In a recent year, Progressive Insurance spent $388 million versus Geico's $827 million, State Farm's $514 million and Allstate's $418 million.

Geico's big budget and visual hammer (the gecko, a reptilian mascot) have created a highly-memorable marketing program for the insurance

giant.

Geico's verbal nail, "15 minutes could save you 15 percent or more on car insurance," is also highly memorable although Geico's massive advertising budget, which dwarfs that of the other major players, is partly responsible for the brand's success.

Geico has also used Neanderthal-like cavemen in a modern setting to promote its Geico brand. The nail, "So easy, a caveman could do it," was memorable, but not very motivating. The real motivation is the 15% or more savings which is lost with the cavemen. Cavemen don't care about savings.

When the nail is weak, it's usually a sign that the marketing people picked the hammer first, which violates the basic principle of nail first, hammer second.

Cavemen might make interesting television spots, but they lack a strong, motivating verbal connection.

However, they were different. As a result, Geico's Cavemen even got their own short-lived TV show.

Allstate

Both Geico and Progressive have been shaking up the auto-insurance business. So much so that long-time leaders like No.1 State Farm and No.2

Allstate felt forced to respond. In 2010, Allstate introduced “Mayhem,” its visual hammer played by actor Dean Winters.

The brand’s verbal nail, however, is a mess. One version goes: “You can save money and be better protected from Mayhem like me.” In another version: “Mayhem is everywhere. Are you in good hands?”

In essence, Allstate now has two visual hammers (Mayhem and Good Hands) and two verbal nails. The resulting confusion is never a good idea. This is particularly true for a brand whose name (All<u>state</u>) is often confused with its leading competitor (<u>State</u> Farm.)

State Farm has a memorable verbal nail (Like a good neighbor, State Farm is there) but lacks a visual. Its “three rings” logotype is a cliché that has been used by many brands in the past including Ballantine Ale (purity, body, flavor.)

On television, State Farm is turning its verbal nail into a “magic jingle.” Sing the good neighbor jingle, point your finger and your wish will come true.

What makes good television? Demonstration, action, motion … all the attributes of the State Farm commercials except one … a visual hammer.

State Farm has none. In the long term, that’s a big mistake, especially for an invisible product like insurance.

Perhaps the oldest visual hammer in the insurance business is the “Rock of Gibraltar,” used by Prudential since the 1890s.

The company’s toll-free phone number (1-800-THE-ROCK) tied into the symbol as well as various verbal nails: “Get a piece of the rock.” And

also: “Strength of Gibraltar.” Time, however, has weakened the rock. It was a good symbol yesterday when print was the dominant communications medium, but not today.

Today, when it comes to insurance advertising, television is the dominant medium. The industry spends many billions of dollars a year on TV advertising.

Having a visual hammer that doesn’t move is a serious handicap on television.

That’s one reason Prudential has been moving away from verbal rock metaphors. “Growing and protecting your wealth” is a recent Prudential slogan. Sooner or later, Prudential will also need a new hammer.

On the other hand, Pacific Life has a hammer that works well on television. The humpback whale which represents qualities such as performance, strength and protection.

The whale was an outgrowth of the Pacific Life Foundation, a non-profit organization dedicated to preservation and conservation of marine mammals.

The Foundation pre-dated the company’s use of the whale in TV commercials.

For more than a quarter century, Snoopy and other Peanuts Characters have served as visual hammers for the MetLife brand.

Currently the MetLife company uses airplanes and blimps to animate its TV commercials.

While the Snoopy hammer is memorable, the verbal nails are weak. They include: “Get Met. It pays.” And: “Have you met life today?” As well as MetLife’s current slogan: “Guarantees for the ‘if’ in life.”

What’s missing in the MetLife program and also missing in most marketing programs today is the notion of locking the hammer and the nail together.

It’s as if a copywriter selects a nail and an art director picks out a hammer and the two never seem to connect with each other. That’s a shame.

Like insurance, a lot of marketing time and money goes into selling pharmaceutical products, but while the pills may be visible, the hammers often are not.

Or if they are, they aren’t exactly appropriate visual hammers.

Take erectile-dysfunction drugs. The first brand in the category (Viagra) made a wise decision to pre-empt a color by using blue pills.

What should competitors have done to differentiate their brands from Viagra? One of the oddest symbols is the twin bathtubs used by the Cialis brand.

Cialis is currently a close second to Viagra, the brand that pioneered the erectile-dysfunction drug category.

And the Cialis brand is widely expected to become the market leader very soon.

The rise of Cialis is remarkable because it was the third drug in the category, after Viagra and Levitra.

(It’s as if Royal Crown, the No.3 cola, suddenly became the cola market leader.)

Why the twin bathtubs? Consider the situation from the company’s point of view. There’s no acceptable way to demonstrate the benefits of an erectile-dysfunction drug.

But the bathtubs convey the idea of two naked people without showing anything remotely exotic.

The verbal nail (the 36-hour drug) also strongly differentiates Cialis from Viagra and Levitra.

Together with the bathtub hammer, they are combining to produce a dramatic marketing victory.

Baking soda is a widely-used household product and the leading brand is Arm & Hammer. Its visual hammer is an old-fashioned arm-and-hammer logotype that dates back to the 1860s.

Once your brand is strongly imbedded in the mind, it is wise to keep changes to a minimum.

With inexpensive products like baking soda, a strong and consistent visual that locks itself with the name makes the brand almost impregnable to competition.

Take salt, for example. Morton has been the leading brand of table salt for many decades.

Morton’s visual hammer is a young girl walking in the rain with an opened umbrella and scattering salt behind her. According to one source, the Morton salt girl (which has been redrawn over the years) is one of the ten best-known symbols in the United States. The verbal nail, “When it rains, it pours,” is not only a benefit of the brand, it’s also a memorable double-entendre.

Car-rental companies provide a service that is invisible and deliberately so. Who wants to rent an automobile with a Hertz logotype on it?

Hertz, however, is trying to increase its visibility with a mascot named Horatio, an animated yellow dashboard figurine with a football-shaped head. Unfortunately, the verbal nail, “We’re at the airport and in your neighborhood,” is one of the blandest slogans ever developed.

We’ll have to wait and see how well Horatio is received by consumers. I have my doubts. He’s not wacky enough to be memorable and his connection to car rentals is almost non-existent.

(Hertz named its mascot after Horatio Jackson, one of the first people to drive a car across America.)

Symbols, whether they are used as visual hammers or not, play an important role in today’s society. On products, on websites, on clothing, on retail stores and on billboards.

The Swoosh, for example, identifies a Nike product in situations where the Nike name might not be readable. Like on an athletic shoe or a baseball hat.

Instead of developing a recognizable symbol, too many companies take the easy way out and use initials instead. Who makes the “N” shoe? Many people probably don’t know.

But most people can readily figure it out. But it still takes awhile to come up with the name, New Balance.

Here's the difference. When you see the Swoosh, the Nike name instantly registers in your mind.

When you see the letter "N," you have to think about it for awhile. And most people won't bother to do so.

When you have more than one name, you need all your initials if you have any real hope of widespread consumer recognition. In fast food, "M" can stand for McDonald's, but could "B" ever stand for Burger King?

The letter "E" is used on a chain of hotels. What hotel chain is this? The street visibility of the Embassy Suites hotel chain might greatly improve by using two initials instead of one initial.

Human minds think in terms of words. If the Face Book logotype were two words, it should have used "fb" as its symbol. But the single word Facebook allows the site to just use "f" as the visual hammer for its button and its icon.

Where the brand has the space, Facebook wisely uses its name and singular blue color for its visual hammer. Words are almost always stronger than just initials.

A tree is a simple shape. One of the most effective visual hammers is the tree used by the Pebble Beach Company as a corporate trademark.

It's a drawing of the iconic "Lone Cypress" tree.

Not only is this symbol memorable, it also deflects consumer attention from the literal meaning of the name, Pebble Beach. After all, consumers tend to prefer sand beaches, not pebble beaches.

The Lone Cypress has been an icon of the Pebble Beach Company for nearly a century which documents both the enduring power of a visual symbol and the need for marketing people to think in decades, not just years.

On the other hand, the DoubleTree hotel chain uses a stylized version of two trees as a trademark.

DOUBLETREE
HOTEL

DOUBLETREE

But the chain has reversed the logical order of things. You have to read the name (DoubleTree) before you can identify these symbols as trees. They look more like ping-pong paddles.

Recently, DoubleTree changed its logotype. The new design demonstrates how verbally-oriented DoubleTree management has become.

Instead of two trees, the DoubleTree trademark now has one tree and one “D.” If your name is DoubleTree how can you show just one tree? And the D is shown after the tree instead of before it? As if the name were TreeDouble. Talk about backward thinking.

This is not a visual that instantly communicates a message. This is a mash-up that needs to be decoded. Let’s see, a tree and a D. What could the

“D” stand for?

Dogwood? Dutch elm? Or maybe the color brown means that it’s a “dead” tree?

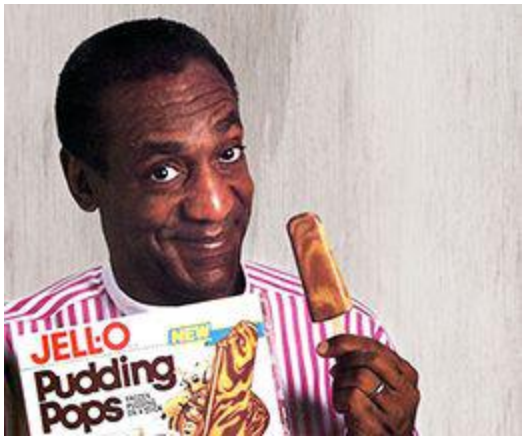
Aah, I have it. DoubleTree.

That’s not good enough. A visual hammer needs to be perceived in a blink of the eye.

A visual hammer is not a puzzle to be solved.

Compare Tommy Bahama with DoubleTree. Not only is the tree a visual symbol for the brand, but it’s obviously a palm tree, a perfect symbol for a “Bahama” brand.

OceanofPDF.com



OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 10

CELEBRITY

PROS & CONS.

A marketing message can't be all message and no come-on. You need to do something to attract consumers to pay attention to what you have to say.

A celebrity can often fill that role.

Nobody, but nobody was as good as Bill Cosby in delivering an advertising message.

In the inductions to the 2011 Advertising Hall of Fame, Mr. Cosby received the "President's award for special lifetime contributions to advertising."

What made Bill Cosby effective? In a word: sincerity.

Consumers are remarkably able to detect celebrities who are just "mouthing the words" as opposed to those who seem to strongly believe in the merits of the product.

Bill Cosby's best work was for Jell-O pudding products, emphasizing key phrases like "Yummy for the tummy" and "Thank you, mother dear," sounding just like some young kid enthralled with having Jell-O pudding for dessert.

Bill Cosby is exactly the kind of celebrity you should be looking for when you launch a new brand.

Cosby also did memorable work for a range of other brands including Crest, Kodak, Coca-Cola and Ford.

Too many marketing people hesitate using celebrities because they figure consumers know they get paid for their endorsements. That's

understandable, of course, but can be overcome by a celebrity who can project absolute sincerity.

As Bill Cosby once said: “I want to make the program interrupt the commercial.”

But there are also three reasons to not use a celebrity as a visual hammer: (1) Celebrities are very expensive and (2) Celebrities aren’t always credible consumers of your product (3) Celebrities are human and subject to human frailties which could damage your brand.

Witness the recent rash of negative publicity about Tiger Woods, Charlie Sheen, Kobe Bryant, Lindsey Lohan, Britney Spears, Martha Stewart and Mel Gibson, to name a few.

It’s always a risk to hire a celebrity as a spokesperson.

Then there’s the expense problem. A-list celebrities are frightfully expensive. In the 15 years before Tiger Woods ran into trouble, according to Golf Digest, he earned $951 million in endorsements.

That’s an average of $63 million a year.

Then there’s the credibility problem. Take Tiger’s endorsement of Buick automobiles. On the surface, this might seem like a good idea.

A young, charismatic, world-class athlete drives a Buick. How could this not improve the perception of the Buick brand?

But wait. In addition to making more money than any other athlete in the world, Tiger Woods also owns a $20-million, 155-foot yacht.

And several years ago, he paid $40 million for a 10-acre property on Florida’s Jupiter Island and promptly tore down the house. In its place, he

built a new mansion, including two pools, a hundred-foot running track, a 5,000-sq.ft. gym and a four-hole golf course.

And he drives a Buick? Highly unlikely.

As you might have expected, Tiger Woods' endorsement of Buick failed to work in the marketplace. Buick sales in the U.S. declined dramatically. From 432,017 vehicles in 2002 to 137,197 vehicles in 2008, a decline of 68 percent.

Another point. If Tiger Woods endorses Buick, who is left to endorse GM's top luxury brand, Cadillac?

God?

(Cadillac needs some help with its hammer which is way too complex.)

It's a stretch, but Tiger in a Cadillac is definitely a plausible endorsement. To quite a few people, the best American cars are on par with the best European and Asian cars. So Tiger drives the "best" American car. A Cadillac, of course.

That's why Tiger's endorsement of Nike, the No.1 athletic-shoe brand in the world, makes sense. But suppose he had endorsed Reebok or Adidas instead?

Would that have worked? Of course, not.

You need to be consistent. The world's best athlete (Tiger Woods) needs to be coupled with a strong leader brand. Not Buick or Reebok.

It's also why Tiger Woods was a good choice for Accenture, one of the world's leading technology and consulting companies. Unlike automobiles and athletic shoes, technology and consulting services are invisible. A celebrity hammer is a particularly good choice for an invisible product. The celebrity can visualize and humanize the invisible.

In the six years that Tiger Woods was the visual hammer for the brand, he greatly improved the visibility of Accenture. The company's revenues also increased from $13.4 billion in 2003 to $23.2 billion in 2009.

In spite of Tiger's domestic troubles, I'm not sure that Accenture should have dropped him. But in hindsight it probably was the right decision. With Tiger's inability to win on the golf course he isn't the hammer he used to be.

After an athlete leaves the field, he or she is quickly forgotten, but not always. A good example is John Madden and "Madden NFL," an American football video game developed by EA Sports.

First introduced in 1988, the game has sold more than 85 million copies, racking up total sales of more than $3 billion. Although retired in 2009 as a broadcaster, John Madden still lends his name to the video game. Will Madden NFL outlive its spokesperson?

There's no reason it can't. Madden is a brand like Orville Redenbacher and Paul Newman. When properly nurtured, a brand can live forever.

One of the most famous recent brand endorsers is Isaiah Mustafa, "The man your man should smell like."

Mustafa is the spokesperson for Old Spice, a Procter & Gamble brand that has been around since 1938.

There's no question that Mustafa energized the old-fashioned deodorant brand. Sales skyrocketed after Isaiah Mustafa videos appeared on the Internet and went viral.

Mustafa became the poster boy not only for Old Spice, but also for social media. He generated millions of unique views as well as a lot of online activity with tweets and blogs. Marketing people went gaga about how Old Spice had reinvented itself.

The real question is, What comes next? And that's always a major problem for a brand like Old Spice with no real connection with its young, handsome spokesperson.

Even the brand's trademark (a sailing ship) is inconsistent with a guy who is more likely to be riding a motorcycle than a 12-foot dinghy.

The verbal idea, however, is strong. "Smell like a man." This reinforces the heritage of the brand and serves as a direct attack on Unilever's Axe, the super-successful fragranced body spray.

Teenage boys bathe in Axe body spray with the hope of attracting teenage girls. Unilever advertising and publicity has humorously labeled this the "Axe Effect."

Years ago, 15-year old Brooke Shields created a similar sensation with her television commercials featuring Calvin Klein jeans.

"Nothing comes between me and my Calvins" was the campaign's memorable verbal nail.

As sensational as the Calvin Klein advertising was, it was obvious that a teenager like Brooke Shields would eventually get older and outgrow her ability to project the right blend of innocence and sexuality.

In the fast-moving fashion category, it probably doesn't matter. Over time, many fashion brands tend to become obsolete. Or the brand just moves on to the next hot model.

Calvin Klein moved his brand to Marky Mark Walberg and Kate Moss and striped them down to demonstrate both their underwear and their bodies.

Can an endorser ever be too old?

Who won the 2010 Super Bowl? You might remember the New Orleans Saints won the football game but do you remember who won the advertising game?

It was the television actress Betty White.

According to USA Today, the Snickers commercial featuring the 88-year-old actress playing football was the most popular advertisement during the Super Bowl. Theme of the spot: "You're not you when you're hungry."

If there is one critical thing you need to know about marketing it is this: Marketing is not a short-term fix. (If you need to do something in the short term, run a sale.)

Marketing is a long-term proposition. Don't think in years, think in decades.

Unfortunately, Betty White is not in a long-term position to endorse the Snickers brand. But even worse, where is the connection between Betty White and a chocolate bar?

There isn't any connection.

It was one funny commercial that did little for the brand.

One of the best examples of the value of long-term consistency involving a celebrity is Charmin toilet tissue.

For 25 years (from 1965 to 1990) Dick Wilson played the role of Mr. Whipple, the retailer who couldn't stop himself from squeezing the Charmin toilet tissue.

In his long career, Dick Wilson did 504 separate TV spots promoting the Charmin brand.

(At one stage of the Charmin campaign, Mr. Whipple was named the third best-known American, just behind Richard Nixon and Billy Graham.)

Charmin is also a good example of the value of a narrow focus. The longtime leader in toilet tissue was Scott Paper Company (now owned by Kimberly-Clark) which started manufacturing toilet tissue in the late 19th century.

But like many companies, Scott couldn't resist line-extending its brand.

So in addition to Scott toilet tissue, the company introduced Scott towels, Scott napkins and Scotties (facial tissue.) Scott maintained its paper leadership position for an awfully long time, but something happened in 1957 that would seriously affect the Scott brand.

That was the year Procter & Gamble bought the Charmin Paper Company.

Not surprisingly, the Charmin family of products included paper towels, paper napkins, facial tissue and toilet tissue, the same range of products made by Scott.

But in those days Procter & Gamble was run by marketing people, not by management types.

So in a classic “narrow the focus” strategy, Procter & Gamble discontinued all Charmin products except toilet tissue and then hired Mr. Whipple to promote the brand.

And instead of promoting all the features of its toilet paper, Procter & Gamble focused on softness.

“Please don’t squeeze the Charmin” was the verbal nail to the Mr. Whipple hammer. And the humor evolved around Mr. Whipple’s inability to resist squeezing the tissue himself.

The Charmin brand has been the toilet-tissue leader for decades. Recently, Charmin toilet tissue had 30 percent of the market with Scott in third place with just 12 percent.

Another long-running advertising campaign featuring a celebrity spokesperson was Maytag’s “Lonely repairman.”

Launched in 1967, Jesse White was the character actor who played the role, replaced in 1989 by Gordon Jump and in 2007 by Clay Earl Jackson. For a number of years, Maytag was the largest-selling washing-machine brand in the country.

One Maytag competitor said: “Their machines cost the same to make, break down as much as ours, but they get $100 more because of the reputation.”

How can you visualize the reliability of a washing machine? You can’t. So most brands use a variety of verbal approaches.

Except Maytag.

Even a totally-absurd concept (Our repairman is lonely because a Maytag washer is so reliable it doesn't need service) can be turned into an effective campaign because it can be visualized.

Did you ever see a marketing plan with pictures? I haven't. A marketing plan is usually nothing but words.

In the future, marketing plans are likely to include visuals along with the words. Take O, the Oprah Winfrey magazine, perhaps the most successful publication launched in the last decade (current circulation of the magazine is more than two million.)

No publisher would say that using the Oprah name on a magazine wasn't a good idea.

But how many of these publishers would have taken the next step: Using Oprah's picture on the cover of every issue?

That's the visual hammer that accounts for much of the success of O magazine.

On the other hand, not using Oprah on most of the OWN (Oprah Winfrey Network) television shows is what accounts for the network's lack of success.

Sometimes, however, the use of a celebrity can actually damage a brand.

Especially when the person chosen is the exact opposite of what your brand stands for.

Take Dell. Back in 2000, the company was eager to get into the consumer market to complement its leadership in business computers.

Not a good strategy, but what was worse was the verbal nail and the visual hammer the company chose for its launch into consumer computers.

"Dude, you're getting a Dell" was the verbal nail in a series of television commercials starring Benjamin Curtis, a 21-year-old college student.

(It didn't help Dell's image that three years later, Curtis was arrested for criminal possession of marijuana.)

Dell sells its products primarily to businesses, not consumers. Even today, more than a decade after the Benjamin Curtis campaign, consumers still represent only 23 percent of the company's total sales.

What do you suppose corporate computer buyers thought when they saw Ben Curtis hawk Dell products? Suppose a chief executive of a major corporation asked his or her IT manager, "What kind of computers are we buying?"

"Dude, we're getting Dells." In a corporate environment, that's not likely to be an appropriate answer.

Dell used to be the world's largest seller of personal computers. No longer. Today, Hewlett-Packard is.

One reason? Dell lost its focus. Yesterday, the brand stood for "direct sales to businesses."

Today, the brand doesn't stand for anything except, "just another personal-computer company."

If you study advertising history, you will find many examples of celebrities (both real and invented) used in marketing campaigns. Most of them last for a few years and then disappear into history. And the companies that hire them are determined to do better the next time.

But the problem is not usually the hammer. The problem is usually the lack of an effective nail.

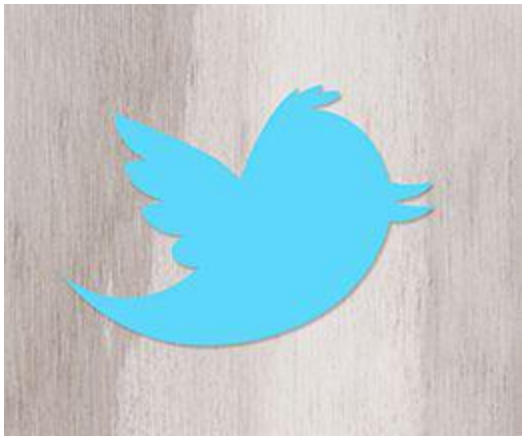
Dick Wilson did a marvelous job as Mr. Whipple, but what built the brand was the "softness" nail.

It was the ability to connect the two, the celebrity hammer and the softness nail, that were the essential ingredients in the brand's success.

And Jesse White, Gordon Jump and Clay Earl Jackson were believable Maytag spokespeople, but what built the brand was the "reliability" verbal nail that made the Maytag repairmen lonely.

Pick the right nail and almost any celebrity will turbo-charge your brand. Pick the wrong nail and even George Clooney will have trouble energizing your brand.

OceanofPDF.com



OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 11

ANIMAL

ANTHROPOPATHY WORKS.

We often attribute human motivation to animals. Courageous people are “lionhearted.” Cowardly people are “chicken-livered.” Greedy people are “piggish.”

People who are playful, but not very serious, are just “horsing around.” People who blindly follow a leader are “sheep.” People who gossip are “catty.”

People who never give up are “doggedly” pursuing their dreams. Lawyers are “sharks.”

People who seldom say anything are “quiet as a mouse.” People who cling to the past are “dinosaurs.”

Animals are also popular as pets in America. We own 86 million cats, 78 million dogs, 16 million birds and some 13 million reptiles. (My two kids own one poodle and two pet rats.)

Because of our familiarity and love of animals, they can also make extremely effective visual hammers.

Look at the visibility of Jaguar, an automobile brand that sold only 12,276 vehicles in the American market in the year 2011.

Compare Jaguar with some brands that sold more vehicles that year. Suzuki (26,618), Land Rover (38,099), Mitsubishi (79,020), Infiniti (98,461) and Acura (123,299).

The jaguar visual and the Jaguar name give the Jaguar brand considerably more street visibility than many brands with much greater sales volume.

What’s missing from the Jaguar marketing program? A verbal nail, of course.

What’s a Jaguar? Most people have no idea.

Take the high-end Nissan brand, Infiniti. Many people know the trademark for the Infiniti brand is a variation of the mathematical symbol for “infinity.” But it’s a weak visual device because it’s used out of context (on an automobile instead of a mathematical paper.) Sometimes out of context is all right, as long as there is some logical connection. But what is the logical connection between the concept of infinity and an automobile?

Does an Infiniti run forever on one tank of gasoline?

A Jaguar automobile, on the other hand, looks like a jaguar animal. Sleek and fast. A great visual hammer, but unfortunately an almost non-existent verbal nail, a fact that has seriously hurt Jaguar sales over the years.

A BMW is the ultimate driving machine. A Porsche is the ultimate sports car. A Mercedes-Benz is the ultimate prestige vehicle.

But what’s a Jaguar? It’s a brand in search of a nail.

Another sleek-and-fast animal is the greyhound, the perfect symbol for Greyhound Lines, still the largest North American intercity bus company with 16,000 daily bus departures to 3,100 destinations.

Combined with the Greyhound visual hammer was one of the most memorable verbal nails in marketing history. “Take the bus…and leave the driving to us.”

Today, however, the verbal nail has been modified and in the process has lost its poetry. “Go Greyhound and leave the driving to us.”

To a logical left-brain executive, the new slogan might seem like an improvement, but it's not.

"Go Greyhound" implies there are plenty of alternate bus companies you can choose.

"Take the bus" (and letting the visual communicate the brand name) implies that Greyhound is such a dominant brand that nobody would ever consider choosing an alternative.

Greyhound Lines has also tinkered with its hammer, at one point adding red and blue stripes, perhaps to symbolize its focus on the American market. Two symbols are never better than one. They only cause visual confusion.

In marketing, simplicity and consistency always trump complexity and variety. While a jaguar seems appropriate for an automobile and a greyhound for a bus, what kind of animal would you pick for a $38-billion conglomerate that's into everything?

Television, motion pictures, theme parks and consumer products, among other things.

How about a mouse? Mickey Mouse made his first appearance in the Walt Disney cartoon, Steamboat Willie. Since then, Mickey Mouse has been featured in some 120 Disney cartoons.

According to one source, Mickey Mouse's image is the most reproduced image in the world. Jesus is No.2. And Elvis is No.3.

Walt Disney once said: “I hope that we never lose sight of one thing: That it was all started by a mouse.” It’s a hopeless task to try to find an effective visual hammer to symbolize an entire company. Especially if that company is a big conglomerate. A better direction is to look for the spark that ignited the brand.

General Electric, the company founded by Thomas Edison the inventor of the light bulb, uses symbolic filaments of a light bulb to spell out the letters “GE.”

Locking the visual to the verbal should be your No.1 objective. One way to do that is by using a double-entendre. One of the best examples is the Merrill Lynch bull. The verbal nail, “Merrill Lynch in bullish on America,” is one of the most memorable slogans ever developed. But what makes the slogan memorable is the visual hammer, which instantly identifies the brand and connects with the slogan.

The lion is the “king of beasts” and could make an effective visual hammer, but it needs a verbal connection. Fidelity, a small banking chain in the South, uses a lion as its symbol and even owns the website lionbank.com. But the verbal connection is very weak. Typical billboard: “Hunting for a loan?”

A clever headline, but not very memorable. You don't usually need to shoot a bank teller to get a bank loan.

If Fidelity were a giant bank, it could use a lion with the verbal hammer "King of Banks." (Look how effective Budweiser has been with a similar approach.)

Next to the lion, the tiger is probably the most-admired animal. And Kellogg's Frosted Flakes has pre-empted the tiger.

In 1952, Kellogg's Frosted Flakes introduced the character, "Tony the Tiger." The alliteration helped build the brand as well as the verbal nail: "They're gr-r-reat!"

America's largest chain of seafood restaurants is not called "Red Seafood" although that might have been a more accurate name than "Red Lobster" since the chain sells a lot more fish and shrimp that it does lobster.

But the Red Lobster name is more memorable and lends itself to a more memorable visual.

The specific (lobster) is always more memorable than the general (seafood.)

In the same way that (tiger) is more memorable than the general (animal.)

More than a hundred years ago, animal crackers were a popular treat for kids. A box of animal crackers contained a variety of animals like lions, tigers, bears and elephants.

Today, the most popular brand is Barnum's animal crackers produced by Nabisco Brands. (The "Barnum" name refers to P.T. Barnum, the famous

entrepreneur whose name is now enshrined in the country's largest circus company, Ringling Bros. and Barnum & Bailey.)

In total, over 54 different animals have been used by the brand on its crackers.

But a better direction would have been to focus on one animal. Pepperidge Farms focused on goldfish.

Goldfish crackers brand greatly outsells the various other animal cracker brands, although animal crackers are really more "cookie" than cracker.

In 1997, Goldfish crackers got an eye and a smile imprint added to tie in with its verbal nail, "The snack that smiles back."

Goldfish crackers are popular with parents of young kids since the snacks are baked and seen as healthier. And kids love to see the little smile as they bite the heads off the fish.

Another company making the mistake of focusing on the general instead of the specific is Accenture. When they used a singular celebrity (Tiger Woods), the advertising resonated with the business community. One can understand why they replaced Tiger Woods, but not why they chose a zoo instead of a single animal. Its recent ads use a variety of animals including elephants, polar bears, giraffes, frogs, sharks and chameleons. (So far, no tigers.)

It's a mistake to use a variety of animals. A visual hammer is a singular idea. Multiple hammers for a single brand don't make sense. Would it have

make sense to feature a dozen different golfers in the original Accenture ads?

I think not.

To create a memorable campaign it's better to focus on one animal. My choice would have been an elephant because it's consistent with Accenture's market and its message.

Accenture's market is big companies. A recent Accenture ad showed an elephant crossing a chasm on a narrow log. Headline: "You're never too big to be nimble."

Integrating your animal hammer with your verbal nail is the key to marketing success.

Recently, Accenture dropped the animals in favor of focusing on clients like Unilever, Marriott, Royal Shakespeare Company and others.

Verbally this move might make sense, but visually it does not. At least the animal visuals had some consistency and memorability. But where is the visual consistency between Unilever shampoo as illustrated in the first advertisement and hotels and actors?

In the absence of consistent visuals, Accenture is apparently counting on a prominent ">" symbol to unify its new campaign. That might make sense for an airline or an automobile, but it doesn't make sense for a consulting firm.

Cows might not sound like a good visual hammer for a chicken chain. Yet they work very effectively for Chick-fil-A, a phenomenally successful chicken-sandwich chain located primarily in the South. Who is the enemy of the chicken sandwich? The answer is obvious.

It's the hamburger sandwich, of course.

So for the last 16 years, Chick-fil-A has used cows in a humorous way to carry its message. A typical billboard shows three cows with sandwich boards that read: “Eat mor chikin.”

Even though closed on Sundays for religious reasons, the average Chick-fil-A unit does about as much business as the average McDonald’s and 135 percent more business than the average KFC unit.

Even without a verbal connection to the brand, a visual symbol can greatly increase brand recognition, especially in a low-interest category like insurance.

Ever since 1974, The Hartford Financial Services Group has used an elk as a symbol of the company. The original television commercials featured Lawrence, a ten-foot-tall, five-hundred-pound elk with eight-point antlers and a thick reddish coat.

What an elk has to do with insurance was never mentioned in the commercials, but they certainly were memorable and helped to establish The Hartford brand.

A better direction with a similar animal is what Deere & Co. is doing with its visual symbol, the deer.

Its John Deere brand, the world's largest-selling farm-equipment brand, has used its famous slogan for many decades. "Nothing runs like a Deere."

Then there's the remarkable transformation of Aflac, the company that brought us the duck. In the year 2000, the company had a name recognition of just 12 percent.

Today it's 94 percent. And sales have gone up just as dramatically.

Aflac sales in the American market went up 29 percent the first year after the duck arrived. And 28 percent the second year. And 18 percent the third year.

When considering the use of a visual symbol, you also need to consider the medium you propose to use. Television is primarily an entertainment medium while radio, newspapers, magazines and the Internet are primarily information media. Television messages should contain entertainment elements or they are likely to be ignored.

Take StarKist, the No.1 brand of canned tuna. For years, its television spots featured Charlie, a tuna dressed as a hipster with a fisherman's hat and glasses.

According to Charlie, he has "good taste" and thus is the perfect tuna for StarKist. But Charlie is always rejected with a note attached to a fish hook that says, "Sorry, Charlie."

The reason: StarKist is not looking for a tuna with "good taste," but rather for tuna that "taste good."

It’s interesting, too, that the No.2 brand of tuna (Bumble Bee) and the No.3 brand (Chicken of the Sea) also use animals to symbolize their brands.

Linking the brand’s name to the visual is also a good direction. Since 1894, the leading cake flour is Swans Down, a brand that uses a swan as its visual hammer.

Gorilla Glue goes one step further by locking its name with both its gorilla visual and its verbal. “The toughest glue on planet earth” is the verbal nail for the brand.

Vlasic, the leading pickle brand, uses a stork as its visual symbol.

But without a real connection to the name, without a verbal nail and without a substantial advertising campaign, Vlasic’s stork is losing much of its effectiveness.

As advertising costs continue to climb, more and more traditional brands like Vlasic are being forced to cut back on their ad budgets.

No brand can afford to rely only on advertising to sustain its visual hammer. A visual hammer has to be able to stand on its own.

That’s why it’s important to develop a visual/verbal strategy that will work effortlessly on your package, on your website and on all of your marketing material.

Take Yellow Tail, an Australian wine introduced in the U.S. market in the year 2001.

Three years later, Yellow Tail became the largest-selling imported wine in the country, a remarkable achievement considering the fact that there are some 6,500 imported wines on the market.

The Yellow Tail visual hammer is a black-and-yellow rendering of a yellow-tailed wallaby (a smaller cousin of a kangaroo) on the label. The advertising features many different objects with tails colored yellow. Typical headline: “Yellow Tail. Now spotted outside Australia.” Some of the objects include a mermaid, a kangaroo, a bird, a peacock, a lobster, a comet and an alligator.

I question the wide variety of visuals. It might have been even more effective to focus on the wallaby only.

But there’s no question the Yellow-Tail advertising and packaging built a strong brand, in part because there was little competitive imported-wine advertising during the early part of the last decade.

Yellow Tail has recently shortened its verbal nail to the innocuous slogan: “Tails, you win.”

Dropping “Australia” is a mistake. A liquor brand need a “country of origin” to communicate its authenticity. Scotch from Scotland is highly valued around the world. But Scotch from Switzerland? That doesn’t make sense.

Saki from Japan. Tequila from Mexico. Champagne from France. Vodka from Russia. Rum from Cuba. A “country of origin” is helpful in positioning a liquor brand.

Not only did Yellow Tail build a wine brand that could last for decades, but it also helped improve the perception of Australia as a country

that produces excellent wines.

Yellow Tail should continue to promote its country of origin. It's good for Yellow Tail and it's good for Australia.

Like wine, bottled water is another category with hundreds of brands fighting for market share.

Because of their distribution strength, PepsiCo's Aquafina and Coca-Cola's Dasani lead the category. And Evian is solidly entrenched at the high end.

One brand recently making progress is Deer Park, a Nestlé brand. It's one of the few water brands that have an instantly recognized symbol. Consider some other middle-level brands: Poland Spring, Arrowhead, Crystal Geyser, Ozarka. How would you visualize them?

The one brand that could be visualized is Arrowhead, but the symbolism is faulty. What does an arrowhead have to do with water? Nestlé verbalized the brand as "mountain spring water" and uses a typical mountain range as a visual device, an idea preempted by Evian.

In over-branded categories like bottled water, it's difficult to develop a unique verbal nail. That's why it's important to use a brand name like Deer Park that can be symbolized with a unique visual. Locking the name and the visual together can pay big dividends in the long run.

What often happens, however, is a lack of coordination between the brand name, the visual hammer and the verbal nail. Confusion has killed more branding concepts than almost any other factor.

Take Hamm's, a regional beer brewed in Minnesota, originally by the Hamm family which accounts for the brand's name. Two brilliant advertising ideas built the Hamm's beer brand. The first was a jingle accompanied by the beating of tom-tom drums. "From the land of sky-blue waters." The second was Sascha, a clumsy, dancing black-and-white cartoon bear.

Sascha, the bear, was so popular it was used for more than three decades.

After a sequence of owners, Hamm's beer is now being marketed by MillerCoors, but it's not the brand it used to be. It's been downgraded to one of the cheap beers found on the bottom shelf.

Too bad. Hamm's could have become another "Coors" with a consistent visual/verbal strategy.

Like many other brands, Hamm's name is unrelated to its visual hammer (Sascha, the bear) and unrelated to its verbal nail (From the land of sky-blue waters.)

As the number of brands proliferate, as life gets more complicated, it becomes more and more important to lock all three elements together.

Three good ideas are not better than one coordinated idea. As society becomes more mobile, as people travel more often to places they might not have visited before, the need for visual hammers has intensified.

Take the retail industry. Most retail chains identify their outlets by names only. Preferably the larger the sign, the better.

Some of the most successful retail outlets, on the other hand, use strong visual symbols to identify their brands. Colonel Sanders for KFC. A

chili pepper for Chili's. A red lobster for Red Lobster. A red target for Target stores.

Outback was the first Australian steakhouse. You might have thought the entrepreneurs who founded Outback would have developed a visual symbol to identify the brand.

Outback should have emulated one of its competitors (LongHorn steakhouse) that uses a "longhorn" symbol to identify its brand.

Marketing deals with three elements: (1) the spoken word, (2) the printed word and (3) the visual. The mind responds to each of these elements quite differently.

When you hear "Outback Steakhouse," you quickly think to yourself "Australian steakhouse."

Not so when you see the words "Outback Steakhouse" on a building. To understand the meaning of printed words, you need to perform an extra step.

You have to translate the visual symbols represented by the type into aural sounds your brain can understand. That takes time and effort so many people don't bother to do so.

Visuals are different. If you are attracted to a visual because of its size, shape or its unusual character, it makes an immediate impression in your mind without the need for an aural translation. That's why unusual animals are usually much more effective than common animals.

That's why the leading high-end delicatessen brand is not called "Pig's Head."

It's called "Boar's Head," even though a boar is nothing but a wild pig. "Boar" is a unique and distinctive word which makes it memorable.

Boar's Head is more likely to be associated with a deli brand than a more generic name like Pig's Head.

Nor is the literal meaning of the Boar's Head brand name much of a handicap.

(The head is one animal part that is seldom eaten except for perhaps Andrew Zimmern on Bizarre Foods.)

A unique and distinctive brand name will develop a secondary meaning that allows consumers to associate the brand with a specific product category. Deli meat in the case of Boar's Head.

In spite of its lack of a verbal nail, Boar's Head is still a successful brand, thanks to its unique visual hammer.

When you can combine the name, the hammer and the nail, however, you can build a brand that is almost bulletproof. Roach Motel is a good example.

"Motel" is a common word, but what makes motel a particularly memorable word is the fact that it is almost never used in connection with a bug or insect killer. There's also the killer nail: "Roaches check in…but they don't check out."

A penguin is an unusual animal which makes it a good choice for a visual hammer. Even though Linux has only five percent of the personal-computer operating-system market, the brand name is quite well-known.

Linux's verbal nail is the brand's unique position as the most popular "open-source" operating system. Compare Linux with Microsoft Windows.

How many people have a strong visual impression of the Windows visual even though the brand itself has a 90 percent market share?

The Windows visual might be attractive and might be symbolic of the function of an operating system, but it just isn't unique and distinctive, thus not very memorable.

Microsoft's use of multiple colors doesn't help either.

In 2005, Google bought a little-known company called Android which had created software for mobile phones. On the heels of the iPhone, Google seemed ready pounce.

While launching its own phone didn't work out as planned, Google introduced Android as a mobile platform to compete with the iPhone.

Along with the technology is the Android visual, the green robot that has become a powerful visual hammer for a brand that is unique and distinctive.

A robot might be an obvious choice for a high technology product, but when the robot combines a simple design with a single color, it can make even the obvious choice stand out.

The same is true of Panda Express. When it comes to Chinese food, using a Panda is also the obvious choice. But Panda Express was first in the

mind and links the visual with the name, which says both Chinese and fast-food.

Currently Panda Express is growing rapidly and is the leader in the Asian restaurant category with a 45-percent market share.

Fast-food restaurants and retailers, in particular, make a serious error in not developing unique visual hammers for their brands.

Retailers tend to be verbally oriented and often look at visuals as nothing more than “decorations for the brand” if they even use a visual at all.

Part of the reason for the rise of chains over local mom & pops is because the chains in general are more likely to develop effective visual hammers.

Not many local Chinese restaurants visually stand out the way Panda Express does.

The same is true when surfing the Internet. Websites need to create unique hammers to get their brands off the ground and into the minds of consumers.

Hundreds of social networking and blogging sites have been launched in the past decade, but none have taken flight quite like Twitter.

Twitter picked a name that could be visualized, focused on 140-character messages and called the messages “tweets.” Locking together these ideas is a killer combination. Twitter currently has over 200 million users.

Twitter has used various bird visuals, but have wisely settled on a simple image and a singular color. Maybe not the prettiest bird in the bush, but it's a very effective visual hammer.

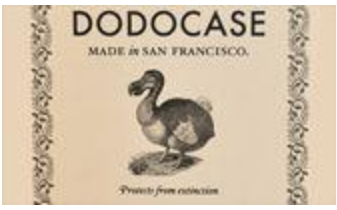
One of the more unusual animals used as a visual hammer is the dodo, a huge bird distantly related to Asian pigeons.

Dodos existed only on the island of Mauritius which prior to 1598 had no human habitation. So it was a lack of fear and a child-like innocence that these birds greeted the first settlers who promptly killed them for food.

By 1681, the last dodo had died.

The dodo is the visual hammer of the Dodocase, a bamboo and cloth iPad cover constructed using traditional book-binding techniques.

The case which only comes in black is creating a buzz among iPad users. When it came to thinking different, Dodocase certainly did.



Dodocase's verbal nail: "Protects from extinction."

Actually, it was the opposite. The dodo couldn't protect itself from extinction, but no matter. The mind just reverses the idea and accepts the Dodocase nail as reality.

One convincing example of the power of the visual is our stoplights.

Heaven help us if our stoplights were verbal instead of visual.

If our stoplights said "stop, go and caution" instead of using colors, the accident rates on our highways would probably double.

Why do so many brands use a verbal approach and ignore the visual? It makes no sense to me.

The owners of these brands should drive around our streets for a while and perhaps they would see the light.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 12

HERITAGE

PUTTING THE PAST TO WORK.

In 2003, in a metal storage bin in Wainscott, New York, 32 paintings were found that looked as if they were made by Jackson Pollock.

Wrapped in brown paper and tied with string, the paintings were labeled in a hand-written note as Pollocks from the 1940s.

Art experts have valued the paintings, if they are genuine, as worth some $10 million. If not genuine, they are almost worthless.

So it is with many products.

A Prada handbag you bought in a store for $1,800 might be worth eighteen hundred dollars. A Prada look-alike handbag you bought on the street for $50 might be worth what you paid for it.

If you are careful where you shop, “fake” brands are not much of a problem today. But “pretender” brands are.

These are brands that look, smell and taste like the big national brands, but nobody knows their names or what they stand for.

Supermarkets, drug stores, clothing stores and all kinds of stores are loaded with many “pretender” brands.

A “heritage” hammer can create authenticity for your brand and keep it out of the “pretender” category. Consumers today are desperate for products and services that are authentic, that are real.

Even a mythological character like Ronald McDonald can help validate a brand. Kids in particular think that Ronald is the guy who owns their favorite fast-food restaurant chain.

And for kids between the ages of two and six, McDonald's is by far their first choice, often dragging parents, who might otherwise prefer Burger King, to Ronald McDonald's place.

What should Burger King have done about the powerful pull of Ronald McDonald?

Nothing. The best strategy is to ignore a competitor's strength and attack them where they're weak. Burger King should have focused on the adult market. (My dad once proposed that Burger King appeal to the teens-and-up crowd with a "Grow up to flame broiling" strategy.)

Instead, the chain emulated McDonald's by installing playgrounds and serving kiddie meals with toys. And to take on Ronald McDonald, Burger King introduced the King.

(The King, an anonymous character in a face mask, looks more creepy than cool.)

It's never a good idea to copy the competition and besides, the King is not a very good copy. Ronald is warm and fuzzy; the King is cold and distant.

Ten years ago in sales per unit, the average McDonald's outsold the average Burger King in the U.S. market by 41 percent. Today, the average McDonald's outsells the average Burger King by 82 percent.

In banks, like in burgers, size is often an advantage. The big banks have more branches, more ATMs and greater street visibility than the small

banks.

There are some 7,000 banks in America, the most of any country in the world. But four big banks dominate the industry: Bank of America, Citigroup, JP Morgan Chase and Wells Fargo. Even though Well Fargo is the smallest of the four, it's the most profitable.

Here are revenues and net profit margins for the four big banks in the past 10 years.

- Citigroup..$1,158.9 billion..8.2 %
- Bank of America..$932.5 billion..10.9%
- JPMorgan Chase..$823.3 billion..10.4 %
- Wells Fargo..$506.6 billion..14.6 %

The stage coach is Wells Fargo's visual hammer, a symbol most people recognize from dozens of Western movies including the classic film "Stagecoach."

Why use an old-fashioned symbol like a stage coach for a banking institution that is highly computerized?

In too many marketing circles there's the perception that "old" is bad and "new" is good.

That's why "innovation" is the driving force at many of America's giant corporations. They want to be on the leading edge with the latest thing.

There's nothing wrong with innovation. "New" is good, but "old" sometimes is even better. "Old" can be the foundation on which to build a strong, up-to-date brand.

The "stagecoach" is a great hammer for Wells Fargo because it symbolizes a company that has been around for more than 150 years.

"Together we'll go far," the Wells Fargo verbal nail, is relatively weak, however. You won't go very far or very fast in a stagecoach. For that, you'd need an airplane.

A better direction for Wells Fargo would have been to emphasize its financial stability. "Other brands come and go, but Wells Fargo has been

delivering financial results for more than 150 years," is the general idea.

Wells Fargo was a real banking and stagecoach company, but a company or a brand can also be successful with a mythical concept.

A vaudeville song, "Old Aunt Jemima," was the original inspiration for an African-American character in 19th century minstrel shows.

So in 1889, a flour producer borrowed the name for a pancake mix and called it Aunt Jemima.

Today Aunt Jemima, now owned by Quaker Oats, is the leading brand of pancake mix as well as a brand name for syrup and other food products.

Intellectually, the average consumer knows that people like Aunt Jemima were obviously invented to sell products, but emotionally it's another story. And here is where a visual hammer plays an important role.

Emotionally, the name and the visual create the perception that Aunt Jemima was a real person and an exceptionally good cook. Otherwise, why would they have called the pancake mix "Aunt Jemima?"

And if the real Aunt Jemima was an invented name, there certainly was no Valley of the Jolly Green Giant punctuated by the Giant's familiar "Ho! Ho! Ho!"

And definitely there was no Betty Crocker or Pillsbury doughboy or Keebler Elves. It doesn't matter. The Jolly Green Giant and the other symbols are hammers that humanize the brands. They make the brands seem more real and authentic. They create an emotional bond with consumers that words alone cannot do.

At one point in time, Green Giant was the leading frozen-vegetable brand in America in spite of the fact that Birds Eye pioneered the category.

In the past decade or so, Birds Eye has recaptured its leadership position, an achievement helped by its credentials as the first brand in the frozen-foods category.

Another factor that undermined Green Giant's frozen-vegetable leadership was the extension of its brand into canned vegetables, a classic mistake and an example of the superiority of the specialist (Bird's Eye) over the generalist (Green Giant.)

Another mythical creature that built a dominant brand is Mr. Clean, the fictional spokesperson for a brand that was launched in 1958. Within six months of its creation, Mr. Clean was American's No. 1 cleaning agent and inspired the longest-running jingle in television history.

"Mr. Clean gets rid of dirt and grime and grease in just a minute."

"Mr. Clean will clean your whole house and everything that's in it."

As successful as Mr. Clean has been, I don't think the next iteration of the brand is going to do nearly as well. Currently, Procter & Gamble is taking Mr. Clean out of the house and using him to open up a chain of car washes.

There are national gas-station chains (Shell), national car-rental chains (Hertz), national fast-lube chains (Jiffy Lube), but not national car-wash chains.

That's an open hole in consumers' minds that will eventually be filled by some brand. But, in my opinion, that is not a hole that Mr. Clean can fill. The brand is too identified as a household cleaner, not as a car wash.

Too bad. Retail establishments located on busy highways desperately need visual hammers.

They need to catch the eyes of passing motorists and instantly communicate the brands and the products or services the brands provide.

The Starbucks mermaid. Target's target. Wendy's pigtails. McDonald's golden arches.

But Mr. Clean? It's going to take a long time to convert a household cleaner into a visual hammer for a car wash.

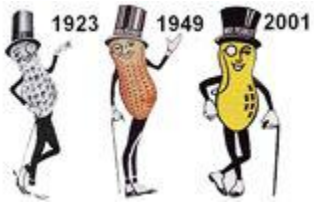
If ever.

Procter & Gamble should have studied the fate of Mr. Peanut when the Planters brand was line-extended into snack foods, including pretzels, potato chips, corn chips and cheese curls.

A nut brand on a potato chip? That didn't make a lot of sense to most consumers.

That's the paradox of marketing. A weak brand name that means almost nothing can be line-extended into different categories. But who wants to do that with a weak brand?

On the other hand, a strong brand name like Planters that dominates the nut category can't be line-extended.



And yet, strong brands are the brands that everyone wants to expand.

Created in 1916 by a Virginia school boy who won $5 in a contest for his drawing of a little peanut person, Mr. Peanut has evolved over the years. The Mr. Peanut cartoon character, in my opinion, was absolutely necessary for the Planters brand to achieve its 40-percent market share.

Consider the name “Planters.” It’s generic. It’s like “Growers” or “Producers” or “Farmers,” all of which would be weak brand names.

Mr. Peanut, the visual hammer, makes Planters seem more like a specific brand rather than a generic name for a category. He also humanizes the brand, always a good idea.

The Indian maiden on packages of Land O Lakes butter also helps to humanize the brand. The maiden has undergone many minor modifications since she was originally painted in 1928. As it happens, the choice of an Indian woman turned out to be a very good idea for a butter brand. She helps to communicate the natural purity of Land O Lakes butter.

A company that launches a new brand often makes the mistake of using an abstract image to communicate the idea that the brand is up-to-date and “with it.”

Like the symbol for Panera Bread. Abstract art like this might resonate with art critics, but not with the general public who might think that, except for the word “Bread,” Panera is a brand of shampoo. Actually, Panera Bread is a very successful national chain.

With 1,324 units and $2.8 billion in annual sales, Panera is the largest “bakery-cafe” chain in America.

But the brand itself could have been even stronger if it had a visual hammer. The current visual needs to be studied very closely in order to realize the lady with the flowing hair is holding a loaf of bread. Most people ignore the “arty” image and focus on the word “Panera.”

Printed words need to be transformed by the brain into aural sounds before they can be understood. That takes time.

And that is why simple visuals hammers because they can be recognized almost instantly are superior to words alone.

With some exceptions, the use of visual hammers to denote heritage seems to be a dying art. Instead, most brand managers want to modernize their packages.

Why modernize a package? Apparently many marketers want to eliminate visual elements that might indicate that their brands are old or out of date.

But like fine Bordeaux wines, for most brands being around for decades is an advantage, not a disadvantage. It must be good, thinks the consumer, if the brand has successfully withstood the test of time.

Take Pepsi-Cola which has been spending millions on new packaging and new advertising to erase its 113-year history. Even worse, the company recently introduced a “throwback” edition of its Pepsi-Cola brand, visually demonstrating the drastic changes that have taken place in the past decades.

Is that a good idea? Especially, is it a good idea to label the front of the can “Made with real sugar?”

All that does is remind people that current Pepsi-Cola products are made with high-fructose corn syrup.

Then there’s the design issue. It’s one thing to make minor modifications to package design, but Pepsi-Cola has pretty much abandoned its past.

The typography is different. The color is different. The logotype has been redesigned several times.

Pepsi-Cola used to be the No.2 cola. Today, regular Pepsi has fallen to third place, after Coke and Diet Coke.

Coca-Cola, on the other hand, has embraced its heritage. The brand still uses the same Spenserian script hand-drawn in 1886, the year Coca-Cola was introduced.

Today, Coke is the world’s most valuable brand. How’s that for progress?

Or rather, lack of progress.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 13

YOUR HAMMER

HOW TO FIND ONE.

Years ago, Bill Bernbach revolutionized the advertising industry by introducing the team approach.

Before Bernbach, a copywriter worked on the copy and then turned it over to an art director to be “visualized.”

Bernbach radically changed the system by assigning teams of two, a copywriter and an art director, and had them work together to first develop the strategy before they created the advertising.

These art director/copywriter teams elevated advertising to a level not seen before. Often called the Golden Era of Advertising and celebrated on TV by the Mad Men series, the team approach is still widely used in the ad business today.

But you don’t need to hire an agency and an expensive art director/copywriter team to get the benefits of this approach for your brand.

Inside your head, you also have a team you can put to work. Your left brain is the copywriter and your right brain is the art director.

Unfortunately, your left brain is a know-it-all, overbearing dictator. It constantly over-rules the visual ideas generated subconsciously by your right brain.

When your analytical left brain concentrates on a problem, logic tends to win over intuition. Your right holistic brain still has a say, but it tends to be overshadowed by the boss on the other side.

As a result, most people wind up being almost totally verbal and analytical. They live in a world of words. They think in words; they write in words; they talk in words.

And thanks to the digital revolution, we are being bombarded with words on a scale never seen before.

Worldwide, 294-billion emails are sent every day. On Twitter, there are 68-million tweets sent every day. Adding to this verbal outpouring are 255-million websites and 152-million blogs.

When you live in a world of words, you tend to see the world of visuals as somehow secondary to verbal reality.

Yet nature is visual, not verbal.

Take a walk in a park. Or scuba dive in the ocean. Or climb a mountain. This is reality and there are no words in nature. Words are useful devices created to help people communicate about the reality of nature.

Photographs and drawings are artificial, too, but they are a more direct representation of nature than are words. They have a visceral impact that words do not.

Take this photograph of a baby. No matter how skillful the writer, no matter how polished the copy, words alone cannot capture the emotional impact of a simple photo.

Words alone cannot replace the emotional impact of the Aflac duck, the Marlboro cowboy, the Coca-Cola contour bottle.

These and hundreds of other visual hammers are creating and maintaining some of the world’s best-known and most-valuable brands.

Yet read a typical marketing plan. Dozens of pages and thousands of words with almost no mention of the role a visual hammer might play.

That doesn’t mean that words are not important. Words are important too, but words have a very hard time getting into consumers’ minds without the driving force of a visual.

A visual hammer makes an emotional impact on the right side of the consumer’s brain which motivates the left side of the brain to verbalize the idea and then store it.

Your right brain doesn’t think in the normal sense of what we mean by “thinking.” It reacts emotionally and involuntarily.

Our emotions are not logical. Try to explain what you mean by love, loss, joy, heartbreak or fear. The emotions are real, but difficult to verbalize.

Before discussing how to counteract the left brain’s tendency to take charge of the creative process, it might be helpful to briefly review the history of visual hammers in marketing. There seems to be three phases.

Phase one: The unrelated hammer.

Some examples: The eye patch for Hathaway shirts. Tony the Tiger for Kellogg’s Frosted Flakes. The stork for Vlasic. The mermaid for Starbucks.

The eye patch, the tiger, the stork and the mermaid are added elements, not germane to the brand itself.

In the short term, unrelated visuals can be surprisingly effective.

For one thing, there’s no need to use a visual symbol that has a logical connection to the brand. The sky’s the limit. You can use the most shocking, the most unusual visual you can find.

In the long term, however, because the visual is unrelated to the brand, it will often lose its effectiveness unless supported by consistent long-term advertising.

Hathaway shirts, for example, used to have a significant market share. Not so today. Ralph Lauren, has replaced Hathaway as the dominate shirt brand.

Phase two: The related hammer.

Some examples: The mustache in the “Got milk” campaign. The duck for Aflac. The gecko for Geico. The polo player for Ralph Lauren.

But wait. Isn’t a polo player just as much an unrelated visual for Ralph Lauren as the eye patch was for Hathaway?

Not exactly. Anybody could lose an eye, but only wealthy people can afford to play polo. The eye patch is a more shocking visual and perhaps attracts more attention than a polo player.

But the polo player communicates “upscale” which is the position the Ralph Lauren brand wants to occupy.

That’s the difference between a related and an unrelated visual. The related visual does a much better job hammering the attribute of the brand.

Especially if the visual is reinforced by a strong verbal, something that Ralph Lauren has neglected to do.

Phase three: The embedded hammer.

Up till now, most hammers were visuals added to marketing programs to improve their effectiveness. The latest, and most dramatic development, is the introduction of visual hammers embedded in the product or service being promoted.

Some examples: The zigzag designs of Missoni. The white earbuds of an Apple iPod. The red soles of Christian Louboutin shoes. The dripping red-wax seal on Maker’s Mark bourbon. The lime on the top of a Corona bottle. The watchband of a Rolex. The Twitter bird.

Embedded visual hammers are far more authentic than related or unrelated hammers.

Does anyone actually believe that Tony the Tiger thinks Frosted Flakes are great?

Or that celebrities get a white mustache when they drink milk?

Or that they actually drink milk?

Furthermore, an embedded hammer will continue to work without a massive advertising campaign, although that's not always desirable. While I have strongly recommended the use of PR to launch a new brand (as advocated in the Fall of Advertising & the Rise of PR) the opposite is true for an established brand.

Advertising is like insurance. Nothing protects an established brand as well as a large advertising budget. Brands like Rolex and Nike and McDonald's and Coca-Cola are almost invulnerable to competition, thanks to the millions of ad dollars these brands spend on protection.

But what if you don't have the resources of Coke or Nike or McDonald's?

Then forget advertising, because unless you can spend enough money to get above the noise level, you might as well spend nothing at all.

The good news is that an embedded visual hammer can help even a small company compete with the giants, no advertising required. An embedded visual is so much more powerful than words alone that it can compensate for the lack of marketing resources by amplifying the power of every sign, website, brochure and tweet you do.

In spite of the effectiveness of the many visual hammers mentioned in this book, there are actually very few brands (in terms of percentages) that have developed and taken advantage of the power of a hammer.

Most brands depend solely on unspecific verbal claims and positions.

Here are some verbal positions for companies starting with the letter A. Like most of the rest of the alphabet, these companies use verbal ideas that can't be visualized.

Aetna: We want you to know.

American Airlines: We know why you fly.

American Cancer Society: The official sponsor of birthdays.

American Express: Take charge.

AT&T: Rethink possible.

Audi: Truth in engineering.

These verbal ideas have meaning, but because they lack visuals, they have little emotional impact. As a result, they are not very memorable.

Why does this happen? Why do brands use purely verbal ideas with no visual hammers?

Typically, a company will develop a positioning strategy, alone or in conjunction with an advertising or marketing agency, that is expressed verbally.

After company executives "sign off" on the verbal strategy, the next step is to execute the strategy with words, pictures, videos.

In other words, romance the verbal idea.

Stop right there. Before you even think about executing a desirable strategy, ask yourself, what is the visual hammer? Most verbal messages are impossible to visualize. How to you visualize "We know why you fly?"

Without a visual hammer, your marketing program lacks the most powerful device in your toolbox.

Let me repeat. A visual hammer is the best, most-effective, most convincing way to get inside a consumer's mind. But 99 percent of all marketing programs lack one.

Yet, in spite of the power of a hammer, the nail is still more important. The nail, after all, is the objective of a marketing campaign. The hammer is only a tool that can facilitate the injection of the nail.

In practice, how can you deal with these two issues, the nail and the hammer, in order to develop an effective, unified marketing campaign?

First, use your left brain to try to express the essence of your marketing strategy in a single word or concept.

Stop. If you're satisfied with your verbal concept, don't think about it anymore. Go for a walk, take a nap, relax in the shower. Daydream for

awhile.

Let your right brain go to work…without constant interruptions from your logical, analytical left brain.

Ask around, you'll find that many great ideas have come to people not my concentrating on the problem but by relaxing and letting the ideas occur to them.

The idea for the Absolut vodka bottle campaign, one of the longest running and most successful advertising campaigns ever, came from art director Geoff Hayes who reported that the idea came to him in the bathtub.

So relax. Hopefully in an hour or two, a visual thought will occur to you…without any conscious effort on your part. That's the way the right brain works. Emotions can't be forced.

But what if no visual idea occurs to you? Then it's back to square one. Try to find another verbal expression of your marketing strategy.

Often you need to sacrifice the effectiveness of a proposed verbal position in order to generate one that can work with a visual hammer.

Take BMW. Years ago, it's easy to imagine that the company might have chosen "performance" as a positioning strategy. That's logical and consistent with the many favorable reviews of BMW vehicles.

But where's the hammer that can drive in a verbal nail called "performance?"

Instead, BMW chose "driving" as its positioning strategy, a verbal concept that could be visualized on television with emotional scenes of happy owners driving their BMWs on winding country roads.

In practice, one soon learns the reason why most marketing programs lack a visual hammer. Their verbal ideas are much too broad.

To develop a visual hammer you need a narrow verbal concept that you can visualize.

Don't fret about a narrow concept not appealing to as many people as a broader one. It's better to use a narrow concept that motivates a segment of the market rather than a broad concept that motivates no one.

It's become increasing clear that we are entering a visual era. Unless a new brand includes and hopefully embeds a powerful visual hammer, the new brand is unlikely to succeed. Paraphrasing an old proverb:

For want of a hammer, the nail was lost.

For want of a nail, the campaign was lost.

For want of a campaign, the brand was lost.

For want of a brand, the company was lost.

The nail is more important, but the hammer is more powerful. That's not an easy concept to grasp.

That's why I wrote this book.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

LAURA RIES

Laura Ries is a leading brand strategist, best-selling author, sought-after-speaker and television personality.

Laura is President of Ries & Ries based in Atlanta, Georgia. She has been working for 18 years with her father and partner Al Ries, the legendary Positioning pioneer.

Together they consult with companies around the world on brand strategies.

They have traveled to over 60 countries from Austria to Australia and Chile to China teaching the fundamental principles of branding.

Laura and Al have written five books together: The 22 Immutable Laws of Branding (1998), The 11 Immutable Laws of Internet Branding (2000), The Fall of Advertising & the Rise of PR (2002), The Origin of Brands (2004), and War in the Boardroom (2009). Visual Hammer (2012) is her first book on her own.

Laura is a frequent branding analyst on major news programs from the O'Reilly Factor to Squawk Box. She regularly appears on Fox News, Fox Business, CNBC, CNN, HLN. In addition, Laura writes her own popular blog RiesPieces.com

In 2008, the Atlanta Business Chronicle named Laura a top 40 under 40. In 2009, Advertising Age asked its readers “What’s the best book you’ve ever read on marketing?” Laura’s book “The 22 Immutable Laws of Branding” was voted number three. (The number one book was Positioning written by her father.) In 2002, Business 2.0 magazine named Laura a “management guru” and issued trading cards with her picture and statistics on them.

Visit Ries.com to find out how to schedule a consulting assignment or to book Laura as a speaker at your next event.

Connect with Laura
Web: ries.com
Amazon: amazon.com/author/lauraries
Twitter: twitter.com/lauraries
Sina Weibo: weibo.com/lauraries
Facebook: facebook.com/visualhammer
YouTube: youtube.com/user/riesreport
LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/lauraries

OceanofPDF.com

Table of Contents

Preface: By Al Ries
Chapter 1 – HAMMER: Its astonishing power.
Chapter 2 – NAIL: The ultimate objective.
Chapter 3 – SHAPE: Simple is best.
Chapter 4 – COLOR: Be the opposite.
Chapter 5 – PRODUCT: The ideal hammer.
Chapter 6 – PACKAGE: Make it different.
Chapter 7 – ACTION: More effective than stills.
Chapter 8 – FOUNDER: Natural-born hammers.
Chapter 9 – SYMBOL: Visualizing the invisible.
Chapter 10 – CELEBRITY: Pros & cons.
Chapter 11 – ANIMAL: Anthropopathy works.
Chapter 12 – HERITAGE: Putting the past to work.
Chapter 13 – YOUR HAMMER: How to find one.
Laura Ries: About the author

OceanofPDF.com